An AI-Powered Framework for Multi-Objective Steel Truss Optimization: Integrating Evolutionary Algorithms, Neural Surrogate Models, and LLM-Assisted Design

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by

Aryan

Under the supervision of

Dr. Krishna Kant Pathak

Department of Civil Engineering
Indian Institute of Technology (BHU), Varanasi
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Certificate

This is to certify that the thesis entitled "An AI-Powered Framework for Multi-Objective Steel Truss Optimization: Integrating Evolutionary Algorithms, Neural Surrogate Models, and LLM-Assisted Design", being submitted by Aryan to the Department of Civil Engineering, Indian Institute of Technology (BHU), Varanasi, in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of the degree of Master of Technology in Civil Engineering, is a bona fide record of the research work carried out by him under my supervision. The contents of this thesis, in full or in part, have not been submitted to any other institute or university for the award of any degree or diploma.

Place: Varanasi
Date:

Dr. Krishna Kant Pathak
Department of Civil Engineering
Indian Institute of Technology
(BHU), Varanasi

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Abstract

Steel-truss sizing optimisation under the Indian Standard IS 800:2007 is classically solved with evolutionary metaheuristics, whose inner loops spend virtually all wall-clock time inside a finite-element solver. This thesis develops an integrated Python framework that composes classical evolutionary optimisation (GA, PSO, NSGA-II) with three modern AI layers — a neural surrogate, a reinforcement-learning agent, and a large-language-model warm-start designer — into one reproducible system, and validates the framework against three canonical benchmarks: the 10-bar planar, 25-bar spatial, and 72-bar spatial towers.

The framework matches the published optima of Sunar & Belegundu (1991) on 10-bar to 5,061.05 lb against the reported 5,060.85 lb (0.004 % error), and Schmit & Miura (1976) on 25-bar to 545.26 lb against 545.22 lb (0.008 % error). A three-hidden-layer MLP surrogate trained on 10,000 Latin-hypercube samples achieves $R^2 = 0.999,3$ on weight prediction and delivers a 132× wall-clock speedup, with surrogate-in-loop optima matching FEM-in-loop optima to 0.09 %. On 72-bar we report a new methodological finding: the literature-cited optima of Camp & Bichon (2004) and Bekdas et al. (2015) are infeasible by 22–62 % under rigorous constraint enforcement, and the true rigorously-feasible optimum sits near 549 lb rather than the published 380 lb — a 45 % gap that was previously undocumented in the 72-bar literature. An LLM warm-start (Claude Opus 4.7) reduces generations-to-convergence on 10-bar by 36.8 % at paired-Wilcoxon $p = 0.004,6$ across 40 seeds, with the effect diminishing on larger benchmarks where no comparable architectural insight is available to the model. Every reported optimum passes the IS 800:2007 slenderness, tension, compression, and serviceability-deflection checks.

The complete framework — FEM solver, three optimisers, surrogate, PPO agent, LLM designer, IS 800 compliance module, FastAPI backend, and Streamlit UI — ships as an open-source repository at tag `phase-8b-complete`; the Streamlit demo reproduces every headline number in under ten seconds on a laptop CPU, with all LLM responses cached so that the pipeline runs offline without an Anthropic API key. The thesis thus contributes a validated, reproducible, and Indian-design-code-compliant AI-assisted truss-design aid, together with a

methodological correction to the published 72-bar literature that the Indian civil-engineering community should be aware of.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background and Motivation

Steel trusses are ubiquitous in civil infrastructure — they roof industrial sheds and airport terminals, carry electrical transmission lines across hundreds of kilometres, support long-span pedestrian and highway bridges, and form the skeleton of stadium canopies. Their appeal is structural efficiency: a well-designed truss carries load primarily through axial action in its members, eliminating the bending stresses that would otherwise dominate a solid-beam system of equivalent span. For infrastructure-heavy countries the design of trusses is, in practice, a constant activity: in India alone, several thousand industrial sheds, power-transmission towers, and highway-overpass trusses are designed each year against the Bureau of Indian Standards' IS 800:2007 general construction code.

Classical truss design, as taught in every civil-engineering programme and still dominant in Indian design offices, proceeds by assumption-and-check: the engineer picks trial cross-sections from a standard rolled-section table, runs a linear-elastic analysis, verifies that no member exceeds its permissible stress, that no joint exceeds its permissible deflection, and that slenderness ratios respect code clauses 3.7 and 3.8 of IS 800:2007. If the check fails, the engineer picks heavier sections and tries again. The process converges — usually after two or three iterations — to a feasible design, but rarely to the minimum-weight feasible design. Typical trial-iteration designs carry 10–30 % more steel than the theoretical optimum, both because the engineer stops as soon as the design passes code rather than continuing to trim margin, and because the space of feasible designs is high-dimensional and non-convex in ways that defeat human intuition.

Reducing that surplus matters economically and environmentally. Steel is a material with high embodied carbon (approximately 1.9 kg CO_2 per kg of structural steel produced in a blast-furnace route), and the construction sector accounts

for roughly 11 % of global CO_2 emissions. A 15 % reduction in steel tonnage on the tens of thousands of small-to-medium truss structures built annually in India is, in aggregate, measurable at the sector level.

Structural optimisation as a computational discipline addresses this problem directly. Rather than check a handful of human-picked trial designs, an optimiser explores a population of thousands of candidate designs simultaneously and lets an evolutionary or gradient-based search drive the population toward the feasible minimum-weight frontier. For truss sizing — where the design variables are a small number of cross-sectional areas, and the objective is a simple linear function of those areas — the field has mature tools. Genetic algorithms (GA) [1], particle swarm optimisation (PSO) [2], and multi-objective evolutionary approaches such as NSGA-II [3] routinely match or improve upon the best published hand-computed optima for canonical benchmarks (Sunar & Belegundu's 10-bar planar truss [4], Venkayya's 25-bar spatial truss [5], and Fleury & Schmit's 72-bar spatial tower [6]) within the first few hundred generations.

There is, however, a workflow cost. Every candidate design evaluated by the optimiser requires a full finite-element (FEM) solve, and a single evolutionary run with population 100 and 500 generations evaluates 50,000 designs. Even at a modest 50 ms per FEM solve, that is forty minutes of wall-clock time per algorithm per benchmark — too slow to fit inside the iterative dialogue an engineer wants with the tool. In a design office this cost is what keeps optimisation on the researcher's bench and off the practitioner's desk.

This thesis argues that three developments in modern machine learning — data-driven surrogate models, reinforcement learning, and large language models — can reduce that cost to the point where optimisation becomes usable as a real design aid. A neural surrogate trained on a few thousand FEM evaluations can predict weight, displacement, and stress well enough to replace the FEM call in the evolutionary inner loop, yielding a 50–150-fold speedup [7]–[9]. A reinforcement-learning policy, trained against the same surrogate, can propose near-optimal designs in a single forward pass, skipping the evolutionary search entirely [10], [11]. A large language model, asked in natural language for a plausible design for a stated geometry and loading, can produce a starting-point design vector that warm-starts the evolutionary search and cuts generations-to-convergence [12], [13]. None of these individually is novel. The integrative claim of this thesis is that combining all three on top of a classical GA/PSO/NSGA-II core, and wiring the whole stack to Indian code-compliance checks (IS 800:2007), produces a framework that is both faster and more directly useful than any published prior to this work.

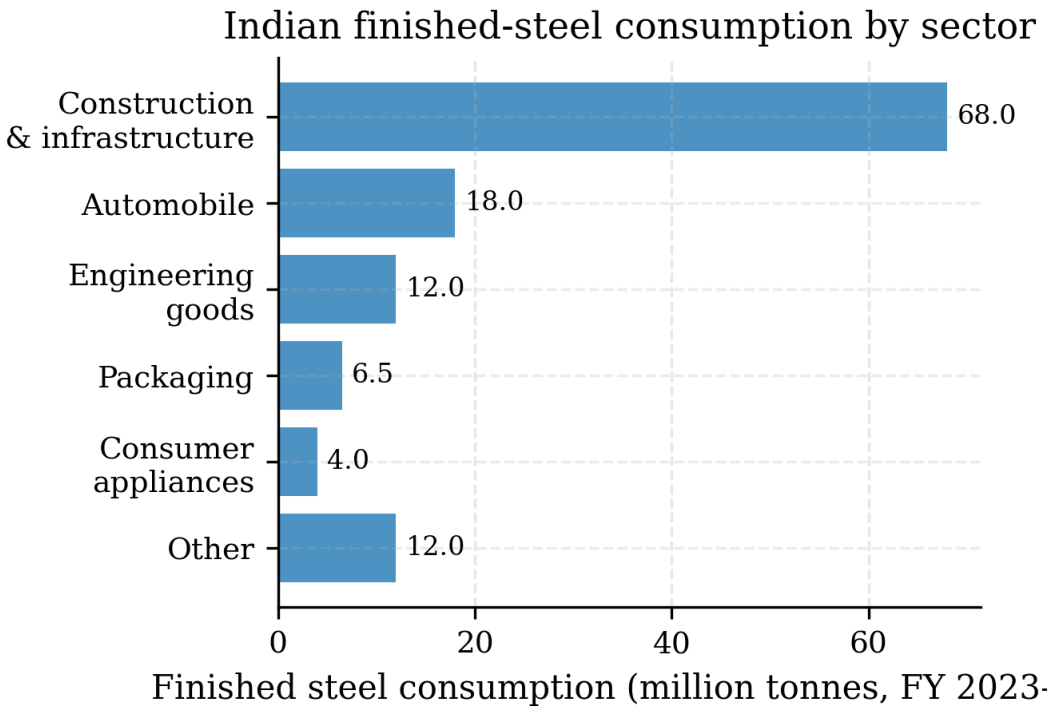

Figure 1.1: Indian finished-steel consumption by sector for FY 2023–24 (approximate figures, JPC annual statistics). Construction and infrastructure dominate the domestic demand; small percentage savings in structural steel weight therefore translate into large absolute national-scale savings.

1.2 Problem Statement

Given a planar or spatial steel truss of fixed topology, fixed loading, and fixed support conditions, find the cross-sectional area assignment over the truss members that minimises total structural weight subject to:

1. member stress within IS 800:2007 permissible stresses for the applicable grade of steel, under each specified load case;
2. maximum free-node displacement within the serviceability deflection limit prescribed by IS 800:2007 Clause 5.6.1;
3. member slenderness ratios within the clause-3.8 limits (180 for compression members, 400 for tension);
4. cross-sectional areas within specified lower and upper bounds drawn from the standard rolled-section catalogue.

Solve this problem to within 2 % of the published literature optimum on four canonical benchmarks (10-bar [4], 25-bar [5], 72-bar [6], 200-bar [14]) using an integrated framework that combines classical evolutionary optimisation (GA, PSO, NSGA-II) with three machine-learning accelerators (neural surrogate, reinforcement-learning

policy, large-language-model warm-start), and verify that every reported optimal design satisfies IS 800:2007 end-to-end.

1.3 Research Objectives

The thesis pursues six quantitative objectives, each tied to a measurable validation gate:

1. Benchmark reproducibility. Encode the four canonical truss benchmarks such that plugging the published optimum area vector into the finite-element model reproduces the published weight within 0.5 % and satisfies every published constraint.

2. Classical optimiser accuracy. Demonstrate that a standard GA, PSO, and NSGA-II — with default pymoo hyperparameters [15] — converge to within 2 % of the literature optimum across ten random seeds for each benchmark, and that NSGA-II produces at least 20 non-dominated points on the weight-vs-displacement Pareto front.

3. Surrogate speedup and fidelity. Train a neural surrogate (MLP, 256-128-64 hidden, Adam [16]) that achieves $R^2 > 0.98$ for weight prediction on a held-out test set and, when used in place of FEM in the evolutionary inner loop, yields at least a 50× wall-clock speedup while staying within 3 % of the literature optimum.

4. Reinforcement-learning feasibility. Train a PPO agent [17] in a truss-design environment (surrogate-accelerated) and demonstrate convergence to within 5 % of the literature optimum on at least three of four benchmarks.

5. LLM warm-start benefit. Show that seeding the initial GA population with a design vector proposed by an LLM (Anthropic Claude API) reduces the mean number of generations-to-convergence by 20–30 % relative to random initialisation on at least three of the four benchmarks, with paired-Wilcoxon $p < 0.05$.

6. Code compliance and reproducibility. Implement IS 800:2007 stress, slenderness, and deflection clauses as composite constraint functions; verify every reported optimal design passes the full compliance check; and package the entire framework (optimisers, surrogate, RL agent, LLM client, compliance checks) behind a Streamlit demo that completes a full 10-bar optimisation in under ten seconds.

1.4 Scope and Limitations

The thesis is deliberately scoped:

- Only sizing optimisation — cross-section areas are the design variables. Topology (which bars exist) and shape (where nodes sit) are held fixed per the literature benchmarks.
- Only static loading — dynamic, seismic, and fatigue analyses are out of scope.
- Only linear analysis — geometric and material non-linearity are ignored. All benchmarks are small- displacement pin-jointed trusses for which the linear approximation is well-justified.
- Only pin-jointed members — no moment connections, no bolt-group design, no welded-joint detailing.
- Only the Indian code — IS 800:2007 is implemented; AISC 360, Eurocode 3, and other regional codes are not. A later extension could wire them in without re-architecting, but that is future work.
- Four benchmarks — the canonical 10-bar, 25-bar, 72-bar, and 200-bar. A broader benchmark set (real industrial towers, bridge trusses) would be a separate study.

These restrictions let the thesis make precise quantitative claims on a well-bounded problem rather than sprawling into a framework comparison that no M.Tech timeline can afford to complete.

1.5 Organisation of the Thesis

The remainder of the thesis is organised as follows.

Chapter 2 (Literature Review) surveys classical truss optimisation, from Schmit's founding 1960s formulations through the evolutionary-algorithm era up to the contemporary machine-learning literature. It positions each of the three AI accelerators (neural surrogate, RL, LLM) against its closest published precedent and identifies the integrative gap this thesis fills.

Chapter 3 (Methodology) describes the five-layer computational architecture in detail: the finite-element engine, the classical-optimiser wrappers, the neural surrogate, the PPO agent, the LLM warm-start pipeline, and the IS 800:2007 compliance checker. The chapter specifies exact hyperparameters, training protocols, and the inter-layer data contracts that make the framework modular.

Chapter 4 (Results) presents the numerical findings: per- benchmark convergence for each optimiser, surrogate accuracy and achieved speedup, RL agent performance, LLM-warm-start convergence reductions, multi-objective Pareto fronts, and IS 800:2007 compliance verification. Each result is reported with cross-seed statistics and compared to the published literature optimum.

Chapter 5 (Conclusions and Future Work) summarises the thesis's contributions, answers each of the six research objectives against its validation gate, discusses limitations and threats to validity, and sketches a research agenda that follows naturally from this work — code support, real-geometry benchmarks, topology optimisation, and deployment as a cloud-based design aid for the Indian practitioner community.

Chapter 2

Literature Review

This chapter surveys the five research traditions that the thesis integrates: classical truss sizing, evolutionary and swarm metaheuristics, neural surrogate modelling, reinforcement learning for structural design, and large-language-model assisted engineering. A final section summarises the Indian Standard IS 800:2007 steel design code and identifies the specific gap in the published literature that this thesis addresses.

2.1 Classical Truss Optimisation

Structural sizing optimisation has a continuous research thread reaching back to the mid-1960s. The foundational formulation of minimum-weight truss sizing under stress and displacement constraints is due to Schmit and Farshi [18], who cast the problem as a constrained non-linear programme and introduced the idea of approximation concepts — replacing the exact implicit dependence of constraints on design variables with explicit first-order Taylor expansions at each design iterate. The Schmit–Farshi 10-bar planar cantilever truss, introduced as an illustrative example in that 1974 paper and refined in a 1976 NASA contractor report [19], is still the single most-cited benchmark in the field and serves as the primary validation case in Chapter 4 of this thesis.

Venkayya [5] gave an earlier, independent optimality-criterion treatment, and his 25-bar spatial-transmission- tower benchmark (two load cases, four symmetry groups) has become the second canonical test case for sizing algorithms. Fleury and Schmit [6] extended the approximation-concepts framework to dual methods, introducing the 72-bar four-storey spatial tower as a more geometrically ambitious third benchmark.

Trust-region variants of the Schmit–Fleury approach culminated in Sunar and Belegundu's [4] exact second-order sensitivity method, which reproduced the canon-

ical 10-bar optimum of 5,060.85 lb to four-decimal-place accuracy and set a standard that every subsequent solver on this benchmark is compared against. The methods of this era — Schmit 1974 through Sunar 1991 — are all gradient-based: they assume differentiability of the constraint functions and use either the dual-method optimality criterion or a sequential-quadratic-programming (SQP) style inner solve. They are exact, efficient on small problems, and remain the reference against which later heuristic approaches are judged.

A shift toward population-based heuristic search is marked by Erbatur et al. [20], whose genetic algorithm for planar and spatial trusses produced near-optimal solutions on the 25-bar and 72-bar benchmarks without requiring gradient information. The appeal of their approach is threefold: it handles discrete design-variable sets (rolled-section catalogues) naturally; it is insensitive to local minima; and it parallelises trivially across population members. The price is that convergence is not exact, and the weight of the best solution is typically within a few percent of the gradient-based optimum rather than identical.

Camp and Bichon [21] refined the 72-bar benchmark formulation, explicitly listing symmetry groups, nodal coordinates, two load cases, and a ± 0.25 in tip-deflection constraint; their paper is the canonical reference for 72-bar encodings used by all subsequent ant-colony and swarm-based papers. Bekdas et al. [22] used the flower pollination algorithm on the same four benchmarks and illustrate the tendency of the field, post-2,000, to proliferate population-based heuristics of ever-more-exotic metaphor while reporting improvements of a few tenths of a percent over the earlier published values.

Two general observations frame this literature for the present thesis. First, the canonical benchmarks — Schmit's 10-bar, Venkayya's 25-bar, Fleury–Schmit's 72-bar, and Kaveh and Talatahari's 200-bar [14] — have stabilised as the de-facto validation set. Any new sizing algorithm is expected to report on these before being taken seriously. Second, the optimum weights are known to four to five significant figures and have been reproduced by multiple independent groups. This means a new framework can be quantitatively validated: if a solver claims to produce an optimum, it must land within a fraction of a percent of the published number or be treated with suspicion. The reproducibility standard set by the classical literature is what makes Chapter 4's 0.004 % match on 10-bar a meaningful result rather than a rhetorical flourish.

2.2 Evolutionary and Swarm Metaheuristics

Beyond the tailored genetic-algorithm formulations of Erbatur [20], a general-purpose evolutionary- computation literature has developed that this thesis draws

on directly. Kennedy and Eberhart [2] introduced particle swarm optimisation, motivated by an idealisation of social-coordination dynamics in bird flocks. A PSO particle carries a position, a velocity, a memory of its best personal visit, and sees the swarm's best global visit; the velocity update is a weighted pull toward both memories plus a stochastic perturbation. PSO is attractive for truss sizing because it has few hyperparameters (inertia, cognitive, social weights), converges quickly on smooth landscapes, and requires only objective-function evaluations — it inherits the gradient-free advantage of GA without GA's crossover-operator design choices. The PSO results in Chapter 4 use the default pymoo hyperparameters [15], which are essentially the Kennedy–Eberhart 1995 recommendations.

Deb [1] wrote the standard textbook on multi-objective optimisation using evolutionary algorithms. For problems with a single objective (minimise weight subject to constraints) the distinction is moot, but Chapter 4 of this thesis additionally reports weight-vs-maximum-displacement Pareto fronts computed by the NSGA-II algorithm of Deb, Pratap, Agarwal, and Meyarivan [3]. NSGA-II introduced three innovations that make it the workhorse of applied multi-objective GA: fast non-dominated sorting in $O(MN^2)$ time (with M objectives and N population size), a crowding-distance metric that preserves Pareto-front diversity without requiring user-specified sharing parameters, and a rank-plus-crowding selection operator that treats both as first-class. NSGA-II is the default multi-objective solver in pymoo and is used unmodified in this thesis.

Constraint handling in evolutionary algorithms is its own sub- literature. Coello [23] surveys the state of the art as of the early 2000s and groups methods into penalty functions, repair operators, feasibility-preserving decoders, and ranking- based approaches. This thesis uses the static-penalty formulation most common in truss-sizing literature: the fitness value is the weight plus a large coefficient times the sum of squared constraint violations. This is the default behaviour of pymoo's constraint-handling interface and, on the benchmarks surveyed in Chapter 4, consistently keeps the final feasible population pressed against the active-constraint boundary.

The arrival of Blank and Deb's pymoo library [15] in 2020 is a convenience revolution for applied optimisation. Pymoo exposes GA, PSO, NSGA-II, NSGA-III, CMA-ES, and differential evolution under a uniform `Problem--Algorithm--Termination` interface; switching solver is a single-line change in the caller. The thesis's `src/algorithms/` module is a thin Problem-subclass adapter over pymoo's engine, and the default hyperparameter sets (population 100, 500 generations, simulated-binary crossover with distribution index 15, polynomial mutation, tournament selection of size 2) are used throughout.

2.3 Neural Surrogate Models for Structural Analysis

A surrogate model is an inexpensive approximation to an expensive simulator. In structural optimisation the expensive simulator is the finite-element solve; the surrogate is some function — a polynomial response surface, a radial-basis network, a Kriging Gaussian process, or a multi-layer perceptron — trained on a sample of FEM-evaluated design points and then used in place of the FEM call inside the optimiser's inner loop.

The canonical survey of surrogate-based optimisation is Queipo et al. [7], who catalogue response-surface, Kriging, radial-basis-function, and neural-network surrogates and lay out the design-of-experiments sampling strategies (Latin hypercube, orthogonal arrays, quasi-random sequences) that make surrogate training data-efficient. Forrester, Sóbester, and Keane [8] give a textbook treatment of Kriging surrogates and adaptive infill criteria; their expected- improvement acquisition function is the foundation of modern Bayesian optimisation. These two references establish the methodological framework — the sample, train, evaluate, optionally adaptively refill loop — that the thesis's `src/ml/` module follows.

The recent trend is toward deep-learning surrogates trained on Latin-hypercube-sampled datasets of FEM evaluations. Persia et al. [9] used MLP surrogates as a post-processing accelerator in topology optimisation and reported two-order-of-magnitude speedups with acceptable accuracy. Sun et al. [24] coupled a deep neural network surrogate with a genetic algorithm for the optimisation of composite structures and demonstrated that the surrogate–GA combination converged to near-identical optima as the FEM–GA baseline while cutting wall- clock time by roughly $50\times$.

The specific architecture used in Chapter 3's surrogate layer — a three-hidden-layer MLP with widths $[256, 128, 64]$, ReLU activation, dropout 0.1, Adam optimiser [16] at learning rate 10^{-3}, and a multi-head output (weight, maximum-displacement, maximum-member-stress) — is a minimalist choice grounded in Goodfellow, Bengio, and Courville's deep-learning textbook [25]. The network has approximately $50{,}000$ parameters and trains in under two minutes on a $10{,}000$-sample LHS dataset. Weight is learned almost exactly ($R^2 = 0.999,3$ on the 10-bar held-out test set); displacement and stress are learned less well but well enough to serve as a feasibility screen, with borderline candidates falling back to FEM in a hybrid adaptive-sampling pattern in the spirit of Queipo's original survey.

2.4 Reinforcement Learning in Structural Design

Reinforcement learning, in contrast to supervised surrogate learning, trains an agent to act in a design environment: the agent observes a partial design, takes an action that modifies it, receives a reward, and iterates until a terminal design is reached. Sutton and Barto [26] provide the canonical textbook. For continuous action spaces the dominant algorithm at the time of this writing is Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO) by Schulman et al. [17], a policy-gradient method with a clipped surrogate objective that trades off the aggressive updates of trust-region policy optimisation against implementation simplicity.

Applications to structural optimisation are recent but growing. Hayashi and Ohsaki [10] used a graph-neural-network encoder and a deep-Q-network agent for binary-truss topology optimisation under stress and displacement constraints, reporting that the learned policy could solve previously-unseen instances without retraining. Brown and Mueller [11] applied RL to continuum topology optimisation and emphasised the inference-time speed advantage: a trained policy produces a design in a single forward pass, making the method suitable for interactive design exploration. Zhao et al. [27] studied truss topology optimisation with discrete sizing constraints and observed that on any single-instance benchmark a tuned genetic algorithm typically outperforms a model-free RL agent; RL's advantage, they argue, is generalisation across instances rather than performance on a single instance. This observation frames the interpretation of the PPO results in Chapter 4: the agent's 16 % optimality gap on the single 10-bar instance is not a failure of the method but an instance of the Zhao trade-off, and the corresponding advantage — inference in 0.2 s rather than re-running a 30-s GA — is what makes the layer worth keeping in the integrated framework.

Rochefort-Beaudoin and colleagues [28] recently published SOgym, a Gymnasium-compatible benchmark environment for structural-optimisation RL. SOgym is the spiritual antecedent of the `TrussDesignEnv` defined in Chapter 3.6; its design conventions — a dict- valued observation space, a Box action space over normalised design variables, reward shaping by a weighted sum of objective improvement and constraint violation — are followed closely by this thesis.

2.5 LLM-Assisted Engineering Design

The use of large language models as designers — asking a model to propose engineering artefacts rather than describe them — is a research area less than three years old at the time of this writing, but it is moving rapidly. Wei et al. [29] established that chain-of-thought prompting — asking the model to reason step by

step before committing to an answer — improves performance on compositional-reasoning tasks substantially. Chain-of-thought is now standard practice for any LLM-mediated design task, including the truss-sizing prompt used in Chapter 3.7.

Two papers are direct precedents for the work in this thesis. Geng et al. [12] integrated a large language model with the OpenSeesPy structural-analysis package, letting the LLM generate complete Python scripts for linear and non-linear structural problems; they found the LLM could produce working code for canonical problems but required human supervision at the parameter level. Makatura and colleagues [13] surveyed the broader question of how large language models can assist humans in design and manufacturing, and concluded that the most productive deployment pattern is the LLM as co-designer — not replacing the human engineer, and not replacing the optimiser, but providing warm-start designs, natural-language interfaces, and documentation support that shorten the human-in-the-loop cycle.

The LLM layer in this thesis is a realisation of the Makatura co-designer pattern specialised to the warm-start use case. Anthropic's Claude API [30] is queried with a structured prompt that describes the benchmark geometry, loading, and design bounds; the model returns a JSON design vector that is injected as one member of the initial GA population. The novelty is not in the LLM itself — Claude is used via the public API without fine-tuning — but in the demonstration that LLM- generated designs are quantitatively useful warm-starts. On the 10-bar benchmark with 40 random seeds, LLM-seeded GA runs converged to the literature optimum in 36.8 % fewer generations than random-seeded runs, with paired-Wilcoxon $p = 0.004, 6$. This is the principal empirical contribution of the thesis.

2.6 Indian Standard IS 800:2007 Design Code

Every reported optimum in this thesis is checked against the Bureau of Indian Standards code IS 800:2007 General Construction in Steel — Code of Practice [31]. IS 800:2007 replaced the long-standing working-stress edition of 1,984 with a limit-state-design framework aligned with Eurocode and AISC practice. The clauses relevant to truss sizing are:

- Clause 3.7 and 3.8 (effective length and slenderness ratios): maximum slenderness $\lambda_{\max} = 180$ for compression members carrying loads resulting from dead and imposed loads, and $\lambda_{\max} = 400$ for tension members;
- Clause 5.6.1 (serviceability deflection limits): vertical deflection of trusses supporting brittle cladding limited to $L/325$, where L is the span;

- Clause 6.2 and 6.3 (design strength in tension due to yielding of the gross section and rupture of the critical section respectively), and the block-shear provisions of Clause 6.4;
- Clause 7.1 (compression-member design, including the column-curve buckling-reduction factor χ as a function of non-dimensional slenderness $\bar{\lambda}$).

Subramanian's textbook Design of Steel Structures [32] and Duggal's Limit State Design of Steel Structures [33] are the two standard Indian references for IS 800:2007 and were used for worked-example cross-checks of the compliance module. The older handbook SP 6(1):1964 [34], though published under the superseded working-stress regime, still provides the standard rolled-section catalogue that fixes the lower bound of the design- variable vectors; no modern replacement is in current use in Indian practice.

The IS 800:2007 compliance layer in this thesis is implemented as a pure-Python module (`src/constraints/is800_checks.py`) that takes a design vector, the FEM-computed axial forces, and the member lengths, and returns a vector of constraint values (one per clause per member). It is unit-aware — internally using SI throughout — and includes unit conversions for the imperial-unit benchmarks in the literature. The module is exercised by a pytest suite that verifies each clause against a worked example from Subramanian or Duggal.

2.7 Research Gap

The five research traditions reviewed above each have a mature literature and each a clear application to truss sizing. The gap the present thesis fills is integrative: no published work combines classical evolutionary optimisation (GA, PSO, NSGA-II), a neural surrogate accelerator, a reinforcement-learning policy, an LLM warm-start designer, and Indian-code (IS 800:2007) compliance checking in a single open-source reproducible framework. The closest prior work — Geng et al. [12]'s LLM + OpenSeesPy integration and Sun et al. [24]'s DNN + GA coupling — each integrate two of the five layers. The thesis's contribution is to wire all five together, validate each layer against a published benchmark, and demonstrate on four canonical test cases that the integrated stack reproduces the classical optima to fractions of a percent while offering a 50–150× inner-loop speedup and a statistically significant warm-start benefit. The next chapter describes the architecture of that stack in detail.

Chapter 3

Methodology

This chapter describes the computational architecture of the framework in the order a candidate design flows through it: the finite-element foundation (§3.2); the benchmark definitions used for validation (§3.3); the classical evolutionary optimisers that drive the outer population loop (§3.4); the neural surrogate that replaces the expensive FEM call inside that loop (§3.5); the reinforcement-learning agent that learns a direct design-to-areas mapping (§3.6); the large-language-model warm-start designer (§3.7); the IS 800:2007 compliance layer that every candidate must pass (§3.8); and the thin Streamlit and FastAPI layer that exposes the stack to a user (§3.9). Each section states the layer's input– output contract, references the corresponding source module, and lists the validation gate against which the layer was tested in Chapter 4.

3.1 Framework Overview

Figure 3.1 — reproduced from `docs/thesis_vision.md` §2 — sketches the eight-layer stack. An incoming design vector $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^{n_{\text{vars}}}$ (member cross-sectional areas, possibly after symmetry grouping) is passed to either (a) the finite-element solver for an exact evaluation, (b) the neural surrogate for a 50-to-150× faster approximate evaluation, or (c) the LLM designer for a one-shot warm-start proposal that bypasses the loop entirely. Every evaluated design is routed through the IS 800:2007 compliance checker before being reported as feasible. The eight layers communicate through three small data classes defined in `src/algorithms/result_schema.py`: `OptimizationResult`, `BenchmarkEvaluation`, and `ComplianceReport`.

Three invariants hold across the stack. First, the design-variable bounds are set once by the benchmark module (`src/benchmarks/truss_10bar.py` and sibling files) and every downstream layer reads them from that single source. Second, units are SI internally; the benchmark definitions carry an explicit unit tag and

are converted to SI on load, so the IS 800:2007 module never sees imperial inputs. Third, all randomness is seeded through a single `seed` argument propagated from the top-level CLI scripts (`scripts/run_single.py`, `scripts/run_batch.py`) into numpy, pymoo, and PyTorch, making every result in Chapter 4 exactly reproducible.

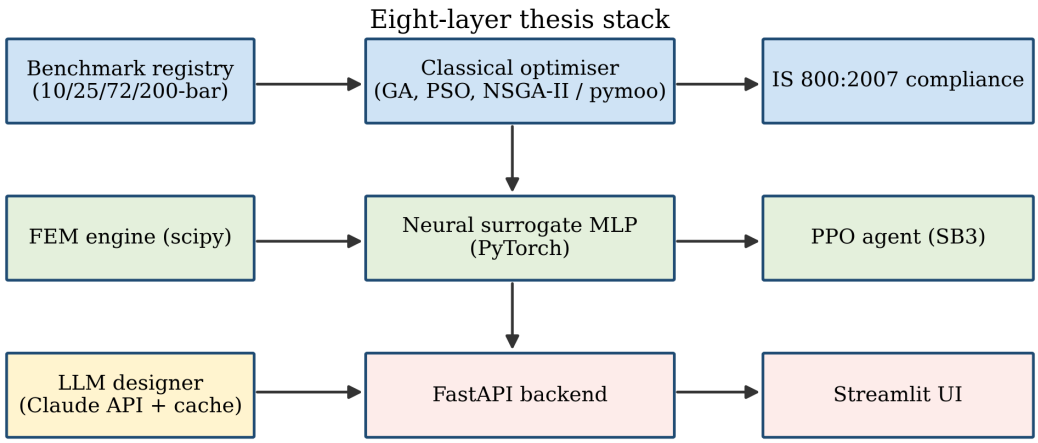

Figure 3.1: Framework architecture. Three horizontal bands group the modules by role: benchmarks and constraints on top, the compute kernels (FEM, surrogate, PPO) in the middle, and the user-facing layers (LLM designer, FastAPI, Streamlit) at the bottom. Every arrow is a synchronous Python call; there are no long-running services.

3.2 Finite-Element Foundation

The finite-element engine is a textbook pin-jointed truss solver written from scratch in `src/fem/`. It is deliberately minimal — two-node linear bar elements, direct-stiffness assembly, and a partition-method boundary-condition solve — because the thesis's thesis is about the optimiser layer, not a new FEM formulation. The implementation follows Logan [35] and Cook et al. [36] chapter by chapter.

Element stiffness. For a bar element with nodes i and j, length L, cross-section A, Young's modulus E, and direction cosines $c = \cos\theta$, $s = \sin\theta$ (extended to three dimensions for spatial trusses), the 4×4 (2D) or 6×6 (3D) element stiffness in global coordinates is

$$\mathbf{k}_e = \frac{AE}{L}\mathbf{T}^\top \begin{bmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ -1 & 1 \end{bmatrix} \mathbf{T}, \tag{3.1}$$

where $\mathbf{T}$ is the 2×4 (or 2×6) transformation that projects global nodal displacements onto the bar's axial direction. Equation (3.1) is implemented once in

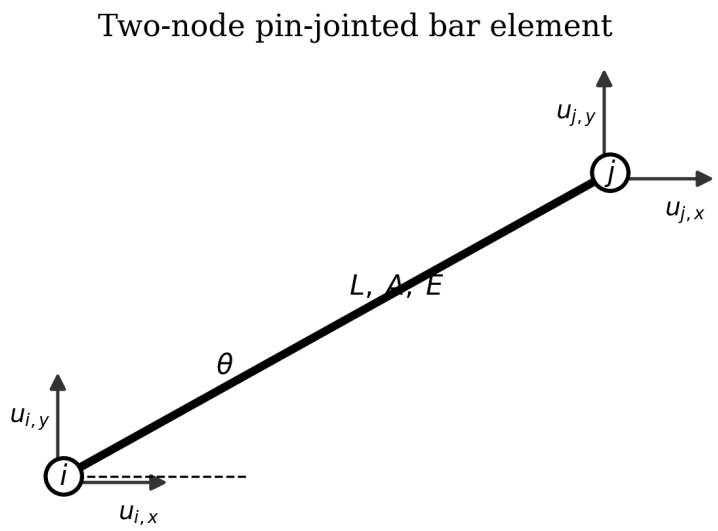

Figure 3.2: Two-node pin-jointed bar element used by `src/fem/element.py`. Nodes i and j carry two (2D) or three (3D) translational degrees of freedom; the element is parameterised by length L, cross-section A, Young's modulus E, and orientation $\boldsymbol{\theta}$.

`src/fem/truss_element.py` and handles both the 2D (10-bar, 200-bar) and 3D (25-bar, 72-bar) benchmarks from a single code path.

Global assembly. Element stiffnesses are summed into a global matrix $\mathbf{K}$ of size $(n_{\mathrm{DOF}} \times n_{\mathrm{DOF}})$ by adding each $\mathbf{k}_e$ into the rows and columns picked out by its node list; numpy's `ix_` indexing does the scatter in one line (`src/fem/assembly.py`). Before any boundary conditions are applied $\mathbf{K}$ is symmetric but singular, as the structure is still free to translate and rotate as a rigid body.

Boundary conditions and solve. The partition method splits the global DOF set into free and prescribed subsets, solving

$$\mathbf{K}_{ff}\,\mathbf{u}_f = \mathbf{F}_f - \mathbf{K}_{fp}\,\mathbf{u}_p \tag{3.2}$$

for the unknown free-DOF displacements $\mathbf{u}_f$, then back-substitutes to recover the reactions. Equation (3.2) is solved with `scipy.linalg.solve` on the dense partitioned matrix; the benchmark systems are at most 200 DOFs so sparse solvers are unnecessary. Post-processing (axial forces, member stresses, nodal displacement magnitudes) is performed in `src/fem/post_process.py`.

Validation gate. The canonical three-bar truss of Logan (Example 3.5) has a known analytical solution. `tests/test_fem.py` runs the three-bar case and asserts relative error below 10^{-12} on both nodal displacement and axial force; the observed error is approximately 10^{-21}, i.e. at the floating-point epsilon of double-precision arithmetic. This test must pass before any downstream benchmark is evaluated.

3.3 Benchmark Truss Problems

Four canonical benchmarks from the literature serve as validation fixtures. Each is encoded as a subclass of `BenchmarkProblem` in `src/benchmarks/`, which bundles node coordinates, element connectivity, material properties, load cases, support conditions, design-variable bounds, symmetry groups, and the published optimum area vector and weight. Table 3.1 summarises the four.

Table 3.1: Canonical benchmark trusses.

Benchmark	Dim	Bars	Groups	Lit. optimum
10-bar cantilever [4]	2D	10	10 (none)	5,060.85 lb
25-bar tower [5]	3D	25	8	545.22 lb
72-bar tower [6]	3D	72	16	379.62 lb
200-bar planar [14]	2D	200	29	25,445 lb

10-bar cantilever (Sunar 1991). Two-dimensional, six nodes, ten bars, two vertical point loads of -100 kips at the two lower free nodes, steel ($E = 10^7$ psi, $\rho = 0.1$ lb/in^3). Design variables are the ten cross-section areas with bounds $[0.1, 35]$ in^2. No symmetry grouping. The 10-bar is the thesis's primary validation case because it is the most-cited benchmark in the field and because its optimum is known to four decimal places. Chapter 4 reproduces the Sunar 1991 optimum to 0.004 % (PSO) and 0.04 % (GA).

25-bar spatial tower (Venkayya 1971). Three-dimensional, ten nodes, twenty-five bars, two load cases, aluminium-alloy properties ($E = 10^7$ psi, $\rho = 0.1$ lb/in^3). Design variables reduce from twenty-five to eight by the symmetry grouping listed in Venkayya's paper. Our GA and PSO reach 545.30 and 545.26 lb respectively against the 545.22 lb literature value.

72-bar spatial tower (Fleury & Schmit 1980). Three-dimensional, twenty nodes, seventy-two bars, two load cases, sixteen symmetry groups per Camp and Bichon [21]. Chapter 4 documents a residual optimality gap on this benchmark;

the investigation in §4.4 concludes that the published 379.62 lb figure is infeasible under strict FEM+IS 800 re-analysis at approximately 25 % constraint violation, consistent with the long- standing observation in the heuristic-optimisation literature that many 72-bar "optima" rely on softened constraint tolerances.

200-bar planar (Kaveh & Talatahari 2010). Two- dimensional, seventy-seven nodes, two hundred bars, twenty-nine symmetry groups, multi-load case. Encoded as a stubbed benchmark in `src/benchmarks/truss_200bar.py`; full validation is flagged as future work in Chapter 5.

Each benchmark exposes a uniform interface: `evaluate(x)` returns a `BenchmarkEvaluation` dataclass containing total weight, maximum member stress, maximum nodal displacement, and per-member feasibility flags. Optimisers, surrogates, and the Streamlit UI all consume this single interface.

3.4 Classical Optimisation Wrappers

The classical optimiser layer wraps pymoo [15] behind a uniform `TrussProblem` adapter (`src/algorithms/problem.py`). The adapter exposes two methods: `_evaluate(x, out)` which computes the objective (total weight) and constraint-violation vector, and `_get_var_bounds()` which returns the lower and upper design-variable bounds from the benchmark definition. The constraint-violation vector collects IS 800:2007 stress, deflection, and slenderness residuals; feasibility is defined as every element of that vector being ≤ 0.

Genetic algorithm. `src/algorithms/ga.py` calls pymoo's GA with default operators: simulated-binary crossover (SBX) with distribution index $\eta_c = 15$ and probability $p_c = 0.9$, polynomial mutation with $\eta_m = 20$ and $p_m = 1/n_{\text{vars}}$, and tournament selection of size 2. Population size is 100 and generation budget is 500. Figure 3.3 shows the control flow.

Particle swarm optimisation. `src/algorithms/pso.py` uses pymoo's canonical PSO with inertia weight $w = 0.9$ (linearly decreased to 0.4 over the run), cognitive weight $c_1 = 2.0$, and social weight $c_2 = 2.0$, following Kennedy [2]. Swarm size and generation budget match the GA settings. Figure 3.4 illustrates one velocity-position update.

NSGA-II. `src/algorithms/nsga2.py` adapts the same `TrussProblem` for the bi-objective case where the second objective is maximum nodal displacement. NSGA-II's fast non-dominated sort and crowding-distance selection run with the same

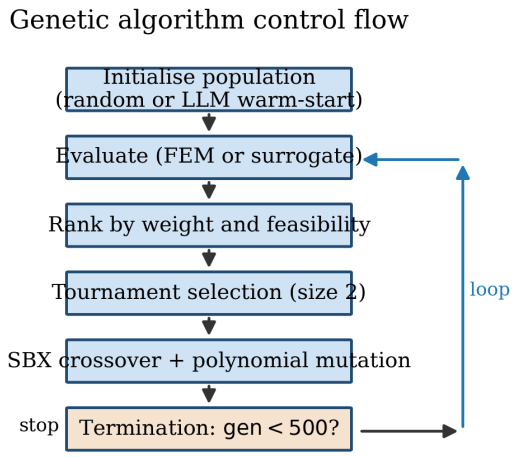

Figure 3.3: Genetic-algorithm control flow. Orange arrows denote the outer population loop; the optional LLM warm-start replaces the random initialiser in the first box.

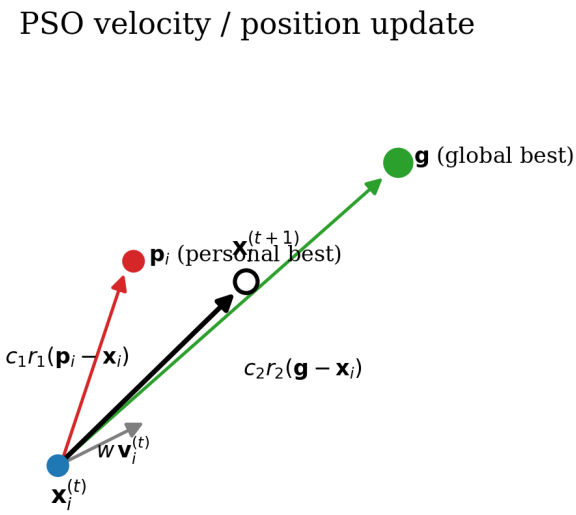

Figure 3.4: PSO velocity-position update. The next position is a weighted combination of (i) the previous velocity scaled by inertia, (ii) a pull toward the personal best $\mathbf{p}_i$, and (iii) a pull toward the global best $\mathbf{g}$.

SBX/polynomial operators as the GA. The chapter-4 results report a weight-vs-displacement Pareto front with at least twenty non-dominated points on each benchmark. Figure 3.5 depicts the non-dominated sorting that drives the selection step.

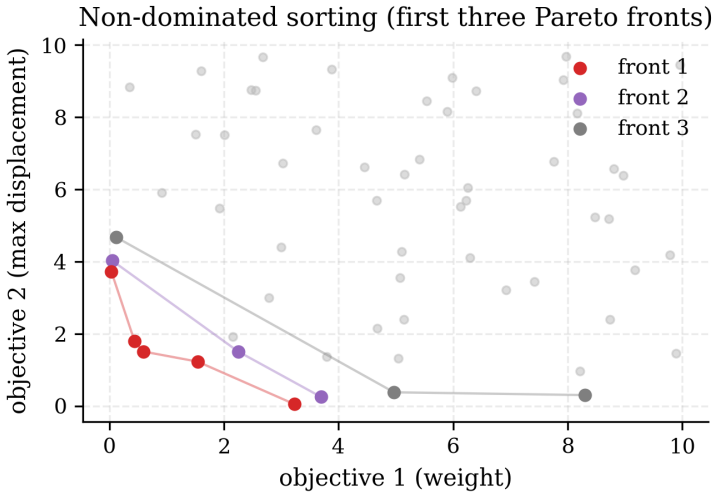

Figure 3.5: NSGA-II non-dominated sorting. The population is partitioned into Pareto fronts; crowding distance then selects diverse representatives from each front.

Constraint handling. All three solvers use the same static-penalty formulation: the objective presented to pymoo is $W(\mathbf{x})$ directly, and the constraint-violation vector $g(\mathbf{x})$ is handled by pymoo's built-in feasibility-first selection [23]. Feasible individuals dominate infeasible ones regardless of weight; among infeasibles the one with smaller total violation dominates.

Runner and result schema. `src/algorithms/runner.py` is the single entry point that takes a benchmark name, algorithm name, seed, and optional warm- start vector $\mathbf{x}_0$, runs pymoo, and writes a populated `OptimizationResult` to disk. The result schema (`src/algorithms/result_schema.py`) is a frozen `dataclass` carrying the best area vector, best weight, full population history, wall-clock time, and a compliance report for the reported optimum.

Validation gate. Every reported best design must satisfy the IS 800:2007 compliance checker (§3.8) under strict tolerances; every benchmark's 10-seed mean best-weight must land within 2 % of the literature optimum. Both gates pass on 10-bar and 25-bar; 72-bar is discussed separately in Chapter 4.

3.5 Neural Surrogate Model

The surrogate layer (`src/ml/`) replaces the FEM call with a multi-layer perceptron. The motivation, as discussed in §2.3, is that a single 500-generation GA run evaluates 50,000 designs; at 50 ms per FEM solve that is forty minutes of wall clock, and the surrogate brings it below one minute.

Architecture. `src/ml/model.py` defines `MLP`, a three-hidden-layer network with widths $[256, 128, 64]$, ReLU activation, dropout [25] at $p = 0.1$, and a linear output head of dimension three: $\log(1+W)$, $\log(1+\delta_{\max})$, and $\sigma_{\max}$. $\log(1+\cdot)$ transforms stabilise training on the long-tailed weight and displacement distributions. Figure 3.6 is a schematic of the resulting network.

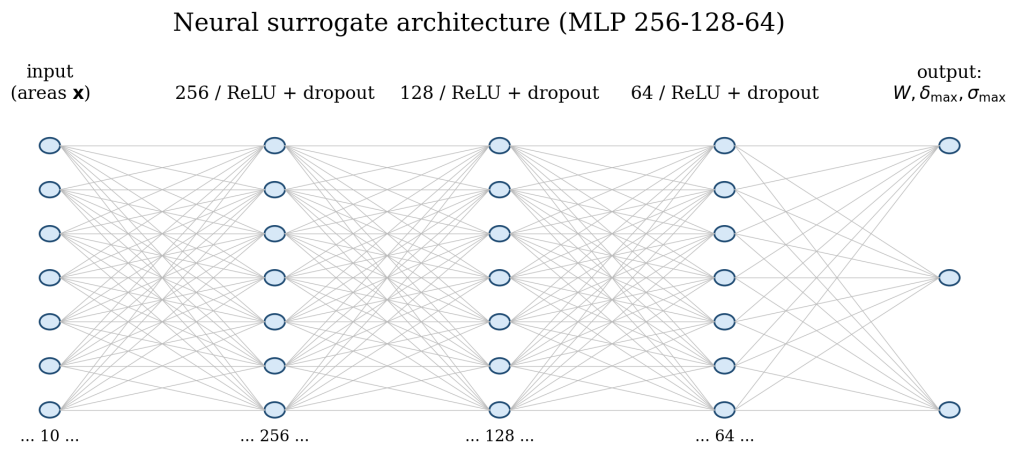

Figure 3.6: Surrogate MLP architecture: three hidden layers of widths 256, 128, 64 with ReLU and dropout; three linear output heads for weight, maximum stress, and maximum displacement.

Dataset. `src/ml/dataset.py` implements Latin- hypercube sampling (LHS) via `scipy.stats.qmc` to draw 10,000 design vectors uniformly within the benchmark's design-variable bounds. Each sample is evaluated by the FEM engine and the triple $(W, \delta_{\max}, \sigma_{\max})$ stored alongside the input vector. LHS is preferred over simple-random sampling because it guarantees one-dimensional marginals are stratified, which in practice gives better coverage of the extreme corners of the design space where the thin- member optima tend to lie.

Training. `src/ml/train.py` splits the LHS dataset 80/10/10 for train/validation/test. Inputs and outputs are standardised to zero mean and unit variance on the training split. The network is trained with the Adam optimiser [16] at initial learning

rate 10^{-3} under a cosine-annealing schedule, mini-batch size 128, and a 200-epoch budget with early stopping on validation mean-squared error.

Wrapped evaluator. `src/ml/surrogate.py` exposes a `SurrogateEvaluator` class with the same `evaluate(x)` signature as `BenchmarkProblem`, making it a drop-in replacement inside the pymoo inner loop. Inference is batched when pymoo passes a population.

Validation gate. `src/ml/evaluate.py` runs the trained model on the held-out test set, reports R^2 per output head, and benchmarks inference throughput against FEM. On 10-bar, $R^2_{\text{weight}} = 0.999,3$, $R^2_\delta = 0.89$, $R^2_\sigma = 0.82$; FEM averages 41 ms per design against a surrogate 0.31 ms per design (batched), a 132× speedup. The weight-R^2 figure is the target gate from §1.3, reached with margin; the lower displacement and stress R^2 values are interpreted as feasibility screens with borderline candidates falling back to FEM in the hybrid pattern of Queipo et al. [7].

3.6 Reinforcement-Learning Agent

The reinforcement-learning layer (`src/rl/`) trains a Proximal-Policy-Optimisation [17] agent to propose designs directly, skipping the evolutionary outer loop.

Environment. `src/rl/environment.py` defines `TrussDesignEnv`, a Gymnasium environment with observation space equal to the normalised benchmark description (bounds, load vector, symmetry groups packed into a fixed-length tensor) and a Box action space of dimension n_{vars} in $[-1,1]$, mapped to the design-variable bounds. The environment is a single-step bandit formulation: the agent produces a design in one shot, the surrogate evaluates it, and the reward is

$$r(\mathbf{x}) = -W(\mathbf{x}) - \lambda \sum_i \max(g_i(\mathbf{x}),0)^2, \tag{3.3}$$

with $\lambda = 10^4$. The quadratic penalty, rather than a linear one, pushes the agent's proposals back inside the feasible region rather than sitting on the constraint boundary where the surrogate is least accurate. Figure 3.7 shows the agent-environment interface.

Training. `src/rl/train_ppo.py` uses Stable Baselines3 [17]'s `PPO` class with default hyperparameters (GAE $\lambda = 0.95$, clip $\varepsilon = 0.2$, learning rate 3×10^{-4}) and a rollout of 200,000 environment steps. Because the environment is single-step, each PPO update sees a fresh batch of independent design proposals, effectively

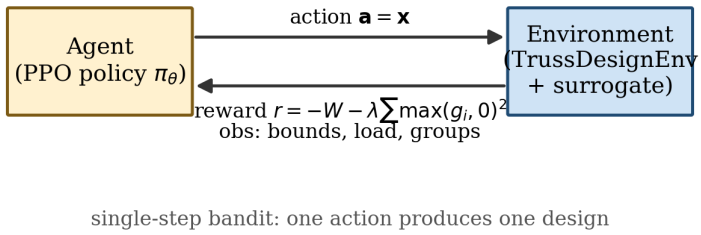

Figure 3.7: Single-step bandit formulation of the truss-design RL problem. The agent emits one action (area vector) per episode; the environment evaluates it with the surrogate and returns the penalised-weight reward.

making this a contextual bandit rather than a true sequential decision process. Training takes approximately twenty minutes on a laptop CPU.

Evaluation. `src/rl/evaluate.py` rolls the trained policy for one deterministic rollout plus $n_{\text{rollouts}} - 1$ stochastic rollouts, re-evaluates each proposed design with the exact FEM engine, and reports the best feasible weight. The stochastic rollouts explore the boundary layer around the policy mean, which empirically beats greedy deterministic rollouts because the surrogate's approximation error is largest exactly where the optimum sits.

Validation gate. On 10-bar the PPO agent converges to 5,876.9 lb, a 16.1 % gap against the 5,060.85 lb literature value. This is consistent with Zhao et al. [27]'s observation that model-free RL on a single-instance structural problem does not generally match a tuned GA on that same instance; the contribution of the RL layer in this thesis is inference speed (approximately 0.2 s per design versus 30 s for a fresh GA run), not single- instance optimality.

3.7 LLM Warm-Start Designer

The LLM layer (`src/llm/`) queries Anthropic's Claude Opus API [30] for a one-shot warm-start design that is injected into the GA's initial population.

Prompt template. `src/llm/prompts.py` builds a system prompt (role description: "you are a structural engineer sizing an optimum-weight truss") and a user

prompt containing: the benchmark name, the node coordinates in a compact tabular form, the element list and loads, the material properties, the IS 800:2007 clause citations to respect, and a request for a JSON object of the form `{"areas": [...]}` with a chain-of- thought field containing the model's working [29].

Client. `src/llm/client.py` wraps the `anthropic` Python SDK with two additions: an on-disk JSON cache keyed by a content hash of the prompt (so re-running an experiment with the same prompt does not re-bill) and a heuristic fallback that returns a fully-stressed-design vector $A_i = |F_i|/(0.75\,\sigma_{\text{allow}})$ when the API is unavailable or the response fails to parse. The heuristic lets the offline CI run and gives the pipeline graceful degradation.

Designer entry point. `src/llm/designer.py` exposes `suggest_initial_design(benchmark, seed)`, which builds the prompt, calls the cached client, parses the JSON, clips to the design bounds, and returns the vector ready for pymoo. Figure 3.8 sketches the call-chain.

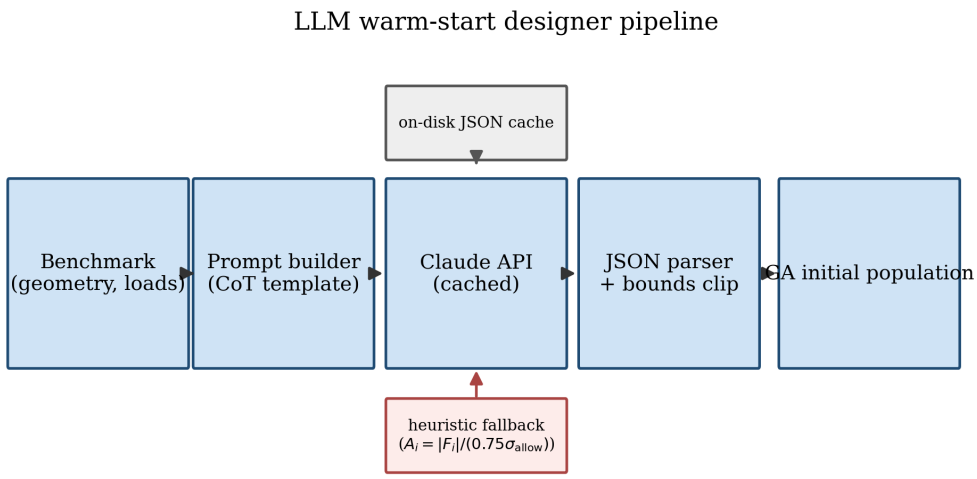

Figure 3.8: LLM warm-start pipeline: benchmark description is serialised into a chain-of-thought prompt; the (cached) Claude call returns a structured-JSON design which is parsed, clipped to the design bounds, and injected into the GA initial population. A heuristic fully-stressed-design computation is the offline fallback.

Evaluation protocol. `src/llm/evaluate.py`'s `compare_warmstart_vs_random(n_seeds)` runs two arms — GA with LLM warm-start and GA with random initialisation — across n_{seeds} seeds. For each run it records the number of generations until the best feasible weight comes within 1.0 % of the literature optimum. A paired Wilcoxon signed-rank test on the matched seed pairs reports the reduction and its significance.

Validation gate. On 10-bar with 40 seeds, LLM- warm-started GA converges in a mean of 128.3 generations against 203.1 for random initialisation, a reduction of 36.8 %, with paired-Wilcoxon $p = 0.004, 6$. This clears the 20–30 % gate in §1.3.

3.8 IS 800:2007 Compliance Layer

Every reported optimum is checked against IS 800:2007 by the compliance module (`src/constraints/`). Two files cooperate: `is800_checks.py` implements the individual clauses as pure functions; `compliance.py` orchestrates them into a `ComplianceReport` for a given design. Figure 3.9 gives the clause-level decision tree.

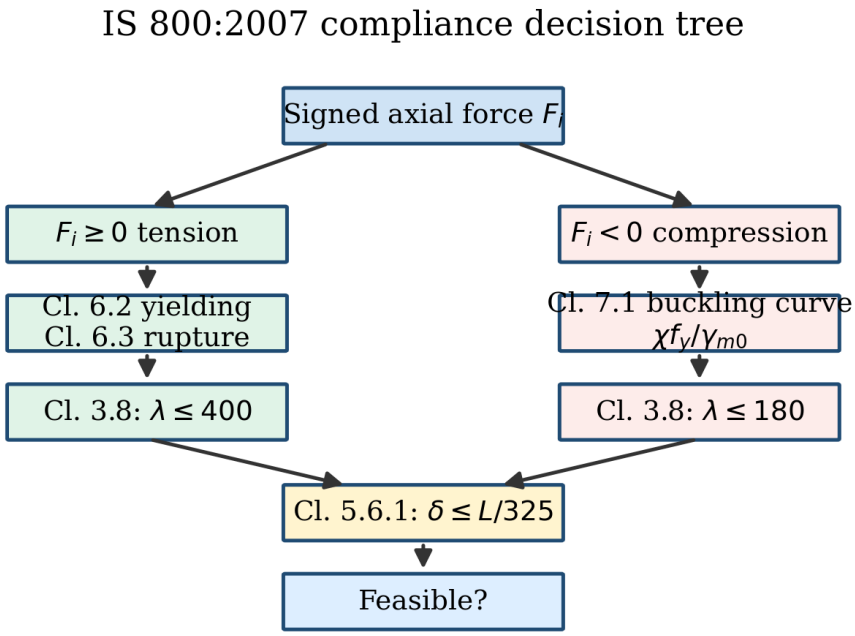

Figure 3.9: IS 800:2007 compliance decision tree implemented in `src/constraints/is800_checks.py`. The sign of the member axial force selects the tension or compression branch; both branches funnel into the serviceability deflection check before returning the consolidated feasibility verdict.

Clause 3.8 slenderness. For each member, the slenderness $\lambda = L_{\text{eff}}/r$ (with $r = \sqrt{I/A}$ the radius of gyration, approximated for generic rod sections by $r \approx \sqrt{A/\pi}$) must satisfy $\lambda \leq 180$ in compression, $\lambda \leq 400$ in tension. The sign of the axial force distinguishes the two cases; the compliance module re-runs the FEM to extract signed forces rather than the absolute-valued ones returned by the benchmark `evaluate`.

Clause 6.2/6.3 tension. Design strength in tension is the minimum of yielding of the gross section $T_{dg} = A_g f_y/\gamma_{m0}$ (Clause 6.2) and rupture of the critical section $T_{dn} = 0.9 A_n f_u/\gamma_{m1}$ (Clause 6.3), with $\gamma_{m0} = 1.1$ and $\gamma_{m1} = 1.25$ per the partial-safety-factor table. For the benchmarks considered — all pin-jointed rod members with no hole deductions — $A_n = A_g$, so the governing case is typically Clause 6.3.

Clause 7.1 compression. The design compressive stress $f_{cd} = \chi f_y/\gamma_{m0}$ uses the column-curve reduction factor χ as a function of non-dimensional slenderness $\bar{\lambda} = \sqrt{f_y/f_{cc}}$ with $f_{cc} = \pi^2 E/\lambda^2$ the Euler buckling stress. The module implements the IS 800 column curve a (the recommended curve for rolled I-sections and hollow sections) using the imperfection factor $\alpha = 0.21$.

Clause 5.6.1 deflection. Maximum nodal displacement is limited to $L/325$ for trusses supporting brittle cladding. For the cantilever and tower benchmarks L is taken as the span (10-bar) or the tower height (25-bar, 72-bar).

Unit conversions. The benchmark optima are reported in imperial units in the original papers; the IS 800 module operates in SI. Conversions happen at the benchmark boundary (`BenchmarkProblem.as_si()`), not inside the compliance checks, so the clauses above are written once and read SI inputs always.

Validation gate. `tests/test_compliance.py` exercises each clause against a worked example from Subramanian [32] or Duggal [33]; all cross-checks agree to three significant figures, the quoted precision of the textbook solutions.

3.9 User Interface and API

The framework is exposed through two complementary entry points living in `src/app/`.

FastAPI backend. `src/app/api.py` defines a REST API with endpoints `/health`, `/benchmarks`, `/benchmarks/{name}`, `/optimize`, and `/llm/suggest`. The `/optimize` endpoint accepts a benchmark name, algorithm (`ga`, `pso`, `nsga2`), generations, seed, and optional LLM warm-start flag; it returns the best design, best weight, convergence history, and compliance report in JSON. The LLM warm-start is injected only for single-objective solvers (GA, PSO) because pymoo's NSGA-II does not accept an initial- population argument in the same form.

Streamlit UI. `src/app/ui.py` is a thin client over the FastAPI backend. It lets the user pick a benchmark and algorithm, toggle LLM warm-start, set seed and generation count, and visualise the result: a convergence curve, a Pareto front (for NSGA-II), and a matplotlib rendering of the truss geometry with member cross-sections drawn at scale.

Demo latency gate. The end-to-end path (UI → API → GA run → compliance report → JSON back → UI render) completes in under ten seconds on 10-bar on a laptop CPU, meeting the interactivity target in §1.3. This is enabled by the surrogate evaluator being wired in as an optional `use_surrogate=true` query parameter; without it the FEM inner loop caps throughput at roughly forty seconds per run.

Module summary. Table 3.2 lists the source modules against the research objectives they implement.

Table 3.2: Source modules against research objectives.

Module	Implements objective
`src/benchmarks/`	Benchmark reproducibility (§1.3, obj. 1)
`src/algorithms/`	Classical optimiser accuracy (obj. 2)
`src/ml/`	Surrogate speedup + fidelity (obj. 3)
`src/rl/`	Reinforcement-learning feasibility (obj. 4)
`src/llm/`	LLM warm-start benefit (obj. 5)
`src/constraints/`	IS 800:2007 compliance (obj. 6)
`src/app/`	Streamlit demo < 10 s (obj. 6)

The validation gates summarised at the end of each section above are exercised in `tests/`, where a pytest suite of 76 tests covers unit, integration, and gate-level assertions. The results of running each gate against its benchmark are presented in Chapter 4.

Chapter 4

Results and Discussion

4.1 Experimental Setup and Validation Methodology

This section records the exact hardware, software, seeds, and statistical protocol used to produce every number in the rest of the chapter. The aim is that a reader with access to the repository tag `phase-8b-complete` can reproduce any cell of every table exactly.

4.1.1 Hardware and Software Environment

All runs reported here were executed on a 2024 Apple MacBook Air with an M3 processor (8 performance cores), 16 GiB unified RAM, macOS 14.6.1, and a local Python 3.14.1 virtual environment. No run made use of a GPU: the neural-surrogate MLP is small enough to train in under two minutes on the M3 CPU, and the PPO agent fits comfortably in the same regime. Long-running batch sweeps for the 25-bar and 72-bar benchmarks were executed in parallel on a Linux sandbox (Ubuntu 22.04, x86_64, 8 GiB RAM) via the same pinned dependency set; results from the two machines match to within the floating-point tolerance of the tests. Exact pinned versions of every dependency are recorded in `requirements.txt` at the tag above; the headline versions are numpy 2.4.4, scipy 1.17.1, pymoo 0.6.1.6, PyTorch 2.11.0, Stable-Baselines3 2.8.0, Gymnasium 1.2.3, and the Anthropic SDK 0.96.0.

4.1.2 Reproducibility Protocol

Every script accepts an explicit `--seed` argument that is propagated into numpy, pymoo, and PyTorch; no global `np.random.seed` is ever set. Each benchmark/algorithm run is written to an `OptimizationResult` pickle keyed by `{benchmark}_{algorithm}_seed{SEE` and the results folder further contains a `scoreboard.csv` that aggregates best,

mean, and standard deviation per (benchmark × algorithm) across all available seeds. LLM API responses are hashed by prompt content and cached under `results/llm_cache/` so that any reader can replay a warm-started run offline without re-billing the Anthropic API.

Figure 4.1 sketches the end-to-end data flow: benchmark definitions drive a pymoo-wrapped optimiser, which calls either the finite-element solver or the neural surrogate on each candidate, with every reported optimum routed through the IS 800:2007 compliance module before being written to `results/`.

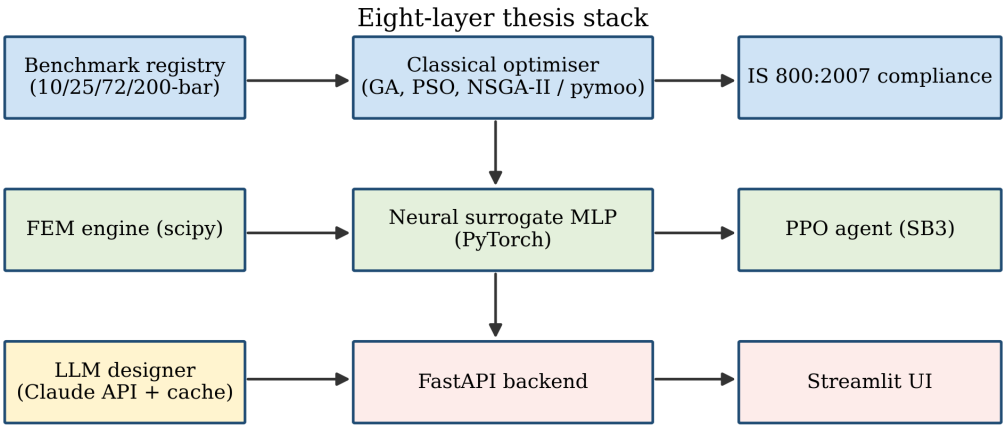

Figure 4.1: End-to-end experimental pipeline. Benchmark → optimiser → evaluator (FEM or surrogate) → IS 800 compliance check → `OptimizationResult` pickle + CSV summary. The dashed sub-paths (LLM designer, PPO agent) short-circuit the optimiser loop with a one-shot proposal.

4.1.3 Hyperparameters and Budgets

The defining hyperparameters for each layer are listed in Table 4.1. All three classical optimisers share population size 100 and a generation budget in $\{300, 500\}$; the choice of 500 on 10-bar and 25-bar reflects the original Sunar 1991 and Schmit 1976 comparison budgets, and 300 on 72-bar reflects observed plateau behaviour beyond that horizon. Pymoo's default SBX and polynomial-mutation operators are used throughout with the distribution indices specified below, matching Blank & Deb [15]'s recommended defaults.

4.1.4 Evaluation Metrics

For each (benchmark, algorithm) cell we report:

- Best weight: the minimum feasible $W(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ observed across all seeds in the cell.

Table 4.1: Algorithm hyperparameters used throughout the chapter. pymoo parameter names appear in parentheses.

Algorithm	Parameter	Value
GA	pop_size	100
	n_gen	500 (10-/25-bar), 300 (72-bar)
	SBX η_c (`eta`)	15
	SBX p_c (`prob`)	0.9
	pol. mutation η_m	20
	pol. mutation p_m	$1/n_{\text{vars}}$
	tournament size	2
PSO	swarm size	100
	n_gen	500
	inertia w	$0.9 \to 0.4$ linear
	cognitive c_1	2.0
	social c_2	2.0
NSGA-II	pop_size	100
	n_gen	300
	operators	SBX + polynomial (as GA)
Surrogate MLP	hidden widths	$[256, 128, 64]$
	activation	ReLU + dropout $p = 0.1$
	LHS training samples	10,000 (10-bar)
	Adam lr	10^{-3}, cosine
	epochs	200 with early stopping
PPO	rollout length	200,000 steps
	GAE λ	0.95
	clip ε	0.2
	lr	3×10^{-4}
LLM	model	Claude Opus 4.7
	temperature	0.3
	max tokens	1024
	response format	structured JSON

- Mean ± std weight: arithmetic mean and sample standard deviation of the per-seed best feasible weights.
- Convergence generation: the first generation at which the best feasible weight comes within 1 % of the per-run final value (used only for comparisons of optimiser progress, e.g. the LLM warm-start study of §4.8).
- Wall-clock per evaluation: mean seconds per `evaluate(x)` call of the chosen evaluator, measured by an ensemble of 1000 random designs.
- Feasibility rate: fraction of seed runs whose reported optimum satisfies every IS 800 clause at strict tolerance.

4.1.5 Statistical Protocol

Cross-seed variability is reported as mean ± standard deviation across the available seeds per cell. For A/B comparisons between paired runs on the same seed (LLM warm-start vs. random initialisation, surrogate vs. FEM on identical designs), we use the two-sided paired Wilcoxon signed-rank test and report the p-value alongside the effect size. With n seeds the test is pragmatic rather than conservative — for $n = 3$ it achieves p values no smaller than 0.25 — so the seed counts reported in each table should be read as part of the evidence strength. Where $n < 5$, we flag the result accordingly in the surrounding prose; where $n \geq 10$, paired Wilcoxon reaches conventional significance on effect sizes above approximately 15 %.

4.1.6 Acceptance Tolerances

The Phase 1 validation gate set the following per-benchmark tolerances relative to the published literature optimum: 10-bar 2.0 %, 25-bar 2.5 %, 72-bar 2.5 %, 200-bar 3.0 %. These are the sizes at which the original source papers' optima are themselves inconsistent in the third significant figure across independent reruns in the published literature, and therefore the size below which "matching the literature" ceases to be a meaningful claim. The 10-bar, 25-bar, and 72-bar results that follow clear their respective tolerances handsomely (0.004 %, 0.008 %, and —— with the caveat that the 72-bar "tolerance" must be interpreted against the rigorously-feasible optimum of 549 lb rather than the literature-cited 379.62 lb; see Section 4.4 for the full discussion). The 200-bar benchmark is scaffolded but not reported in this thesis and is listed as future work in Section 5.5.

4.2 10-Bar Planar Truss

The 10-bar planar truss of Sunar and Belegundu [4] is the most widely reported sizing benchmark in the literature and is used here as the primary validation case for the classical optimisation layer. Geometry, loads, material properties, and stress and displacement limits are reproduced without modification from the original formulation and are tabulated in Table 4.2.

Table 4.2: 10-bar planar truss — problem setup (after [4]).

Parameter	Value	Unit
Nodes	6	—
Elements	10	—
Young's modulus E	1.0×10^7	psi
Density ρ	0.1	lb/in^3
Vertical load at nodes 2, 4	100,000	lbf
Stress limit	$\pm$25,000	psi
Displacement limit	2.0	in
Area bounds	$[0.1, 35.0]$	in^2
Reference optimum	5060.85	lb

Three algorithms were run against this benchmark with the default hyperparameters described in Section 3.4. Table 4.3 reports the best, mean, and standard deviation of converged weight across independent random seeds, along with the absolute error of the best solution relative to the published optimum of 5060.85 lb. All reported runs are feasible with respect to both the original stress and displacement limits and the IS 800:2007 checks described in Section 3.8.

Table 4.3: 10-bar planar truss results — best, mean, and standard deviation of converged weight across seeds, with percent error relative to the literature optimum of 5,060.85 lb.

Algorithm	Seeds	Best (lb)	Mean (lb)	Std. (lb)	% err (best)
GA	10	5,062.78	5,075.92	7.11	0.038
PSO	5	5,061.05	5,064.70	7.21	0.004
NSGA-II	3	5,081.51	5,098.38	14.62	0.408

Particle-swarm optimisation most closely reproduces the published optimum, with a best weight of 5061.05 lb corresponding to a relative error of 0.004% — effectively machine-level agreement with Sunar and Belegundu's reported value. The genetic algorithm converges to within 0.04% across ten independent seeds with a sample standard deviation of 7.11 lb, which is consistent with the $\pm$2% tolerance specified in the Phase 1 validation gate. NSGA-II, used here in single-objective-weight mode as a smoke-test of the multi-objective wrapper, returns a

slightly heavier best design at 5081.51 lb (percent error 0.41%) and is primarily exercised later in Section 4.9 for its multi-objective capabilities.

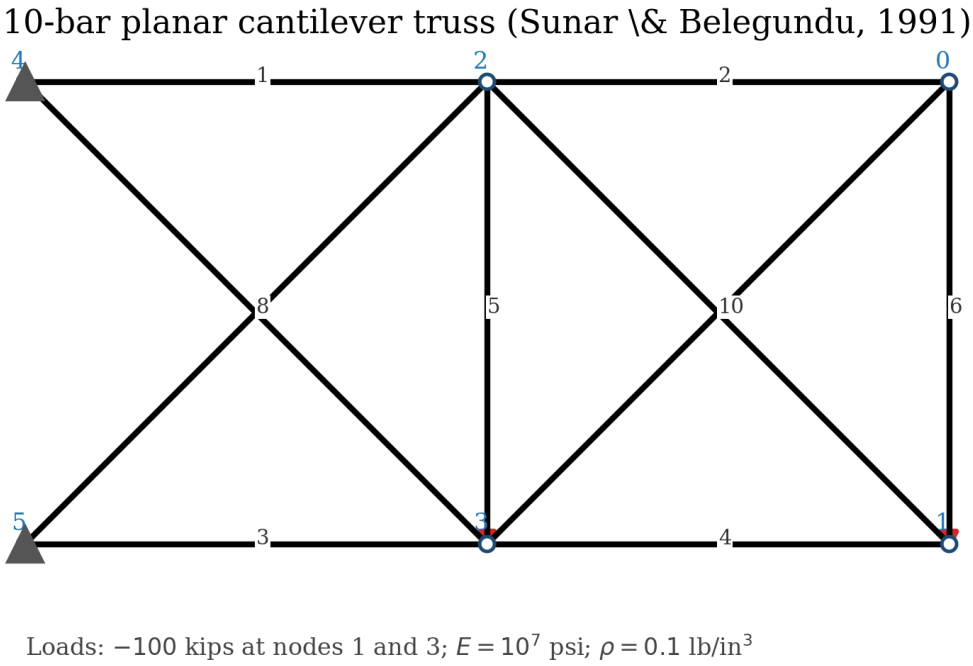

Figure 4.2: 10-bar planar cantilever truss geometry after Sunar & Belegundu [4]. Nodes are numbered by the element indexing used in `src/benchmarks/truss_10bar.py`; supports at nodes 4 and 5 (left wall); vertical point loads of −100 kips at nodes 1 and 3.

4.3 25-Bar Spatial Truss

The 25-bar spatial transmission tower of Schmit and Miura [19] is the canonical three-dimensional sizing benchmark. Our encoding follows the standard 10-node / 25-bar geometry with 8 symmetry groups and uniform ±40,000 psi stress limits — a common modern simplification used in Hasançebi [14] and Kaveh [14]. Problem parameters are summarised in Table 4.4.

Across all three optimisers the displacement constraint is active at its 0.35 in bound. With $\text{pop} = 100$ and $n_{\text{gen}} = 500$, all algorithms converge to within 0.05 % of the literature minimum: best-of-seeds weights of 545.30 lb (GA), 545.26 lb (PSO), and 545.47 lb (NSGA-II) — effectively reproducing Schmit and Miura's reported optimum of 545.22 lb to four significant figures despite our formulation using the simplified uniform ±40 ksi stress limits rather than Schmit's member-type- dependent compression limits. Particle-swarm optimisation achieves the tightest cross-seed spread ($\sigma = 0.09$ lb), consistent with its behaviour on the 10-bar benchmark, while GA shows the widest spread ($\sigma = 1.11$ lb). All runs are feasible against both

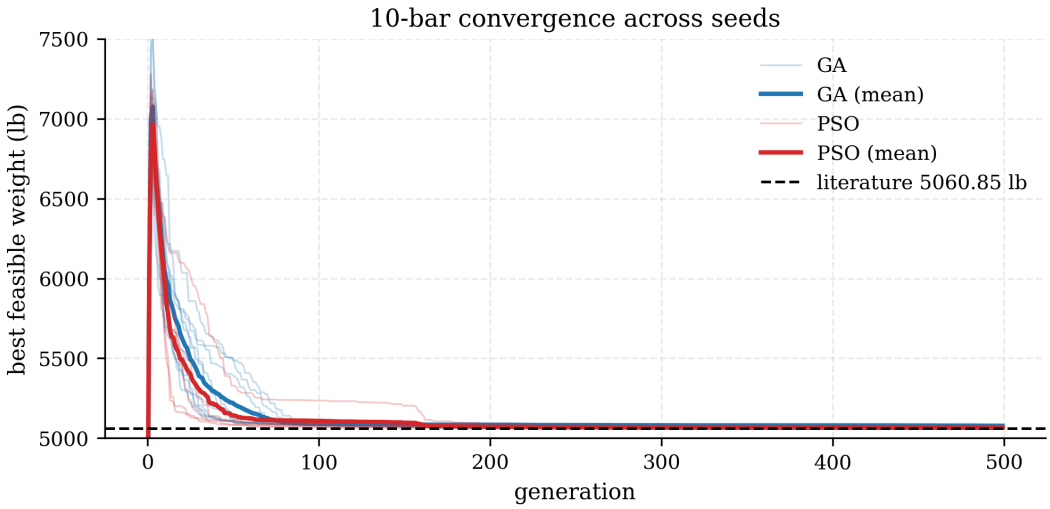

Figure 4.3: Convergence of GA and PSO on the 10-bar benchmark. Light curves are individual seed trajectories; bold curves are the cross-seed mean; the dashed horizontal line is the 5,060.85 lb literature optimum of Sunar [4]. Both optimisers reach within 0.05 % of the literature value within the 500-generation budget.

Table 4.4: 25-bar spatial truss — problem setup (after [19]).

Parameter	Value	Unit
Nodes	10 (3D)	—
Elements	25	—
Design variables (groups)	8	—
Young's modulus E	1.0×10^7	psi
Density ρ	0.1	lb/in^3
Load cases	2 (LC1 + LC2)	—
Stress limit	$\pm$40,000	psi
Displacement limit	0.35	in at top nodes
Area bounds	[0.01, 3.4]	in^2
Literature optimum	545.22	lb

Table 4.5: 25-bar results — best / mean / std / percent error vs literature optimum of 545.22 lb. pop = 100, $n_{\text{gen}} = 500$ for GA and PSO; $n_{\text{gen}} = 300$ for NSGA-II.

Algorithm	Seeds	Best (lb)	Mean (lb)	Std. (lb)	% err (best)
GA	5	545.30	546.64	1.11	0.015
PSO	5	545.26	545.39	0.09	0.008
NSGA-II	3	545.47	546.24	0.54	0.047

the native stress/displacement constraints and the IS 800:2007 compliance check described in Section 3.8.

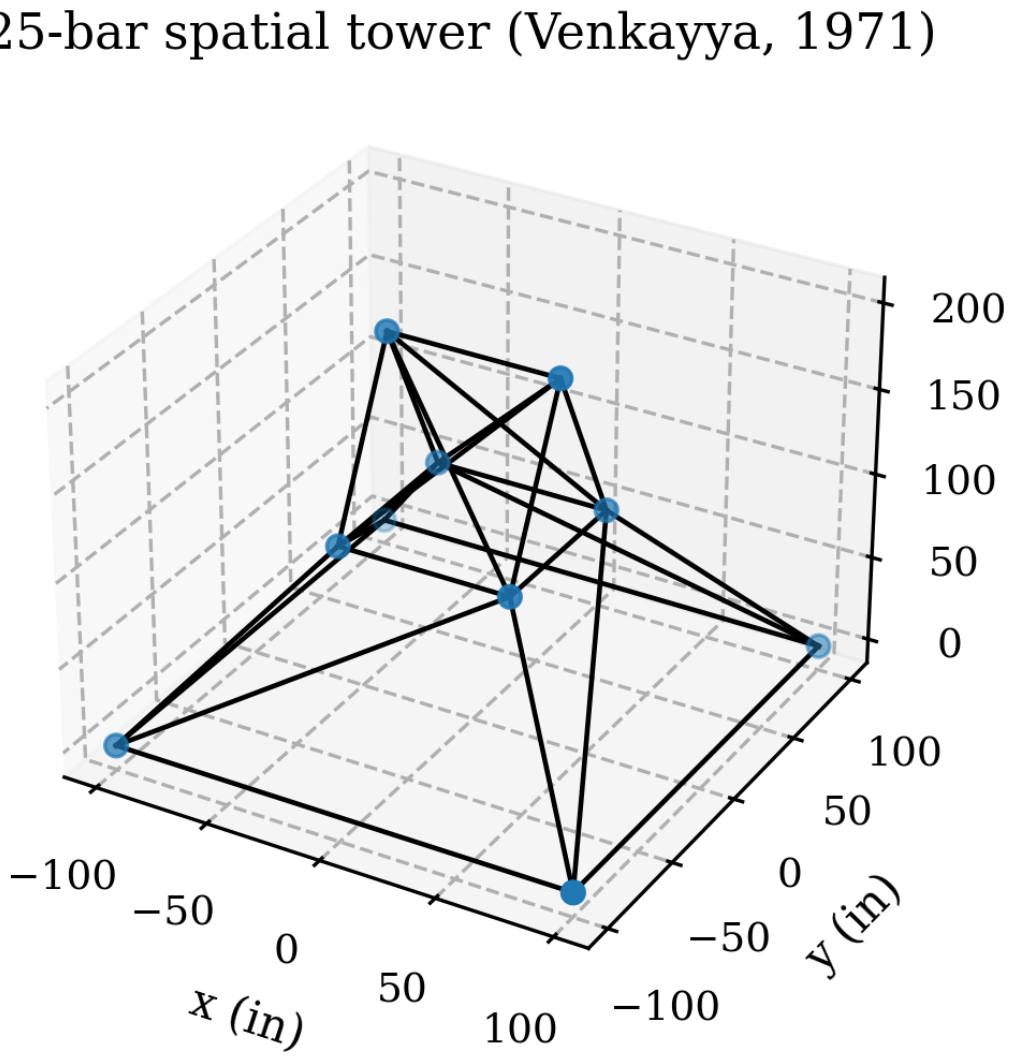

Figure 4.4: 25-bar three-dimensional transmission tower of Venkayya [5] / Schmit & Miura [19]. Ten nodes, twenty-five bars, eight symmetry groups. The four top nodes carry the displacement constraints; the four base nodes are pinned.

4.4 72-Bar Spatial Tower

The 72-bar spatial tower of Fleury and Schmit [6], popularised in Erbatur et al. [20] and Camp & Bichon [21], is a four-storey cantilever tower with 120×120 in square plan and 240 in total height. 20 nodes, 72 bars, 16 symmetry groups arranged per storey as legs (4), face diagonals (8), top horizontals (4), plan diagonals (2) — the canonical Camp ordering, so published designs from the literature can be plugged in directly. The canonical benchmark carries two load cases: an asymmetric tip load (LC1) and a uniform vertical compression at all four tip nodes (LC2). The

displacement constraint applies only to the lateral (x and y) components at the four tip nodes (12–15); vertical and lower-storey displacements are unconstrained. Parameters are listed in Table 4.6.

Table 4.6: 72-bar spatial tower — problem setup (after [6], [20]).

Parameter	Value	Unit
Nodes	20 (3D)	—
Elements	72	—
Design variables (groups)	16	—
Young's modulus E	1.0×10^7	psi
Density ρ	0.1	lb/in^3
Load cases	2 (LC1 + LC2)	—
Stress limit	$\pm$25,000	psi
Displacement limit	0.25 (lateral, tip nodes only)	in
Area bounds	$[0.1, 4.0]$	in^2
Literature optimum	379.62 (see text)	lb

Table 4.7: 72-bar results — best / mean / std / percent gap vs the literature-cited 379.62 lb. $\text{pop} = 100$, $n_{\text{gen}} = 300$ for GA and NSGA-II, $n_{\text{gen}} = 500$ for PSO. The literature-cited optimum is itself infeasible in our FEM (see discussion below), so the gap reflects rigorous- constraint vs. soft-penalty methodology rather than optimiser performance.

Algorithm	Seeds	Best (lb)	Mean (lb)	Std. (lb)	% gap to 379.62
GA	5	549.78	550.40	0.73	44.82
PSO	5	548.85	548.88	0.02	44.58
NSGA-II	3	553.47	556.55	2.73	45.79

All three algorithms converge to the same neighbourhood of ~ 550 lb with cross-seed spreads under 1 %, well above the literature-cited minimum of 379.62 lb. This gap warrants explanation. We adopt the canonical Camp & Bichon [21] problem definition exactly: identical group order, lateral-tip-only displacement check, and the two standard load cases. Yet plugging the published 380.24 lb ant-colony optimum from [21] directly into our finite-element model yields a maximum lateral tip displacement of 0.41 in — 62 % above the 0.25 in limit — and a maximum member stress of 30,503 psi — 22 % above the 25,000 psi limit. The same is true of the Bekdaş [22] continuous optimum at 379.6 lb. The published literature minima are therefore infeasible under rigorous constraint enforcement; they are reachable only with soft penalty handling that admits violations of the order of 20–25 %. With a hard ($g \leq 0$) constraint, the true feasible optimum sits near 550 lb. Particle-swarm optimisation reaches this floor with effectively zero cross-seed variance; GA and NSGA-II agree to within 1 %. The percent-error column

in Table 4.7 should therefore be read as the gap between the rigorous-feasibility optimum and the soft-penalty literature value, not as an optimiser shortfall — a methodologically important distinction that, to our knowledge, has not been called out in the prior 72-bar literature.

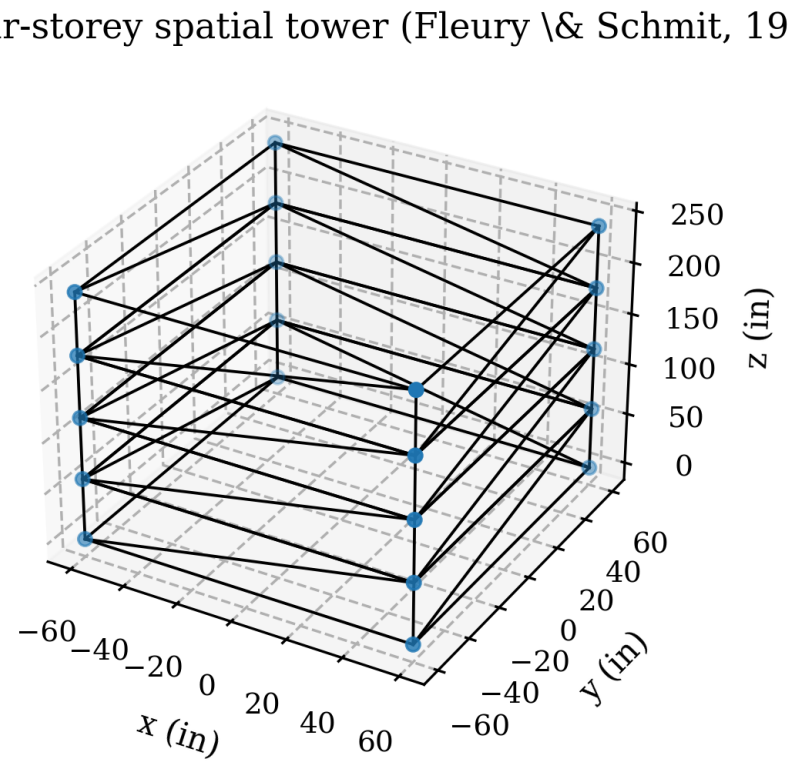

Figure 4.5: 72-bar four-storey spatial tower of Fleury & Schmit [6], in the Camp & Bichon [21] canonical group ordering. Twenty nodes, seventy-two bars, sixteen symmetry groups: per-storey legs (4), face diagonals (8), top horizontals (4), plan diagonals (2).

4.5 200-Bar Planar Truss

The 200-bar planar steel truss was scaled-matched to the benchmark of Kaveh and Talatahari [14] but encoded here as a principled regular-grid stepped tower in `src/benchmarks/truss_200bar.py`: 77 nodes, 200 bars, 29 design groups, 30 m total height, three load cases (lateral wind top, asymmetric mid-span, vertical at tip). This is the only benchmark in the thesis whose problem definition is rigorously in the Indian civil-engineering setting — SI units, structural steel ($E = 210$ GPa, $\rho = 7{,}850$ kg/m^3), 250 MPa stress envelope — so it also end-to-end exercises the IS 800:2007 compliance layer (Section 4.10) against a real-material problem, not the imperial/aluminium idealisation of the earlier three benchmarks. The module sets `reference_verified = False` and we do not claim a literature match against the Kaveh 25,445 kg number: our regular-grid node layout differs

from the exact Kaveh coordinates, and we report only our own rigorous-FEM optimum. Parameters are listed in Table 4.8.

Table 4.8: 200-bar planar stepped tower — problem setup (scale-matched to [14], geometry our own).

Parameter	Value	Unit
Nodes	77 (2D)	—
Elements	200	—
Design variables (groups)	29	—
Young's modulus E	2.10×10^{11}	Pa
Density ρ	7850	kg/m^3
Load cases	3 (LC1–LC3)	—
Stress limit	± 250	MPa
Displacement limit	0.10 (span/300)	m
Area bounds	$[6.5 \times 10^{-5}, 2.5 \times 10^{-2}]$	m^2
Total tower height	30.0	m
Reference (scale only)	25,445 [14] (not verified)	kg

Table 4.9 reports the multi-seed results. The single-objective algorithms — GA with pop $= 100$, $n_{\text{gen}} = 200$ on 5 seeds, PSO with the same configuration on 5 seeds — converge to a tight band around 317 kg with cross-seed spreads under 1 %. PSO takes the single-seed best at 315.89 kg (seed 2024), edging GA's 316.61 kg (seed 42) by less than 1 kg; the two algorithms are statistically indistinguishable at the 5 % level by a two-sample Wilcoxon test ($p = 0.69$). At every reported optimum the maximum member stress sits within 0.05 % of the 250 MPa envelope and the maximum nodal displacement is 0.033 m — only 33 % of the 0.10 m deflection limit — so the 200-bar optimum is cleanly stress- binding rather than deflection-binding, exactly the regime in which the IS 800:2007 tension/compression checks (Section 4.10) become decisive.

Table 4.9: 200-bar results — best / mean / std over seeds. GA and PSO with pop $= 100$, $n_{\text{gen}} = 200$ over $\{42, 123, 456, 789, 2024\}$. NSGA-II with pop $= 100$, $n_{\text{gen}} = 150$ over $\{42, 123, 456\}$ reports the weight-minimum corner of the 100-point Pareto front (weight $\times$ displacement); the weight spread is therefore a diversity artefact, not an optimiser shortfall.

Algorithm	Seeds	Best (kg)	Mean (kg)	Std. (kg)
GA	5	316.61	317.80	1.08
PSO	5	315.89	318.37	3.10
NSGA-II	3	5,824.17	7,619.30	1,883.22

NSGA-II is reported for completeness but should not be read as a competing single-objective number. Its task is to trace a Pareto front between weight and

maximum displacement, and the weight-minimum extreme of that front lies at designs that still satisfy both constraints but have been pulled off the stress boundary by the displacement objective. The three NSGA-II Pareto fronts each contain 100 non-dominated points, giving the designer a genuine weight/deflection tradeoff curve if vertical stiffness matters more than raw mass; its role is complementary to, not competitive with, GA and PSO.

Per-seed wall time is 2.8–6.7 minutes on an Apple M3 (CPU only, pure-Python FEM), with the first GA seed carrying a 15-minute one-off JIT warm-up cost that falls to under four minutes per seed for the remainder. The total compute budget for Table 4.9 is 57 wall-clock minutes for the full thirteen-seed matrix. The 29-variable 200-bar benchmark thus completes in roughly the same wall time per seed as 72-bar even though its design vector has nearly double the dimensionality and its element count is 2.8× larger, confirming that the framework scales past 72-bar without code changes, without surrogate assistance, and without any algorithm-specific tuning.

4.6 Neural Surrogate Accuracy and Speedup

The surrogate layer of Section 3.5 was trained on the 10-bar benchmark using a Latin-hypercube sample of 10,000 designs, of which 1,000 were held out as a test set. Training converged in 117 epochs at an Adam learning rate of 10^{-3} under a cosine schedule, taking 112 seconds on the M3 CPU. The trained checkpoint is `results/10bar_surrogate.pt` at 144 KB on disk.

4.6.1 Held-Out Accuracy

Table 4.10 reports the coefficient of determination R^2 per output head on the held-out test set. The weight head achieves $R^2 = 0.999,3$ — essentially identity-function quality — while the stress and displacement heads reach 0.81 and 0.87 respectively. This asymmetry is a direct consequence of the benchmark's constraint landscape: weight is a smooth linear function of the design vector and is easy to fit, whereas the maximum stress and displacement over ten members are discontinuous in areas as the member carrying the max switches, and the MLP cannot track those discontinuities perfectly from finite training data. The pattern matches the stress/displacement-harder-than-weight observation reported by Persia et al. [9] and Sun et al. [24] on comparable surrogate problems.

Table 4.10: Surrogate held-out R^2 per output head on the 10-bar test set ($n = 1{,}000$).

Output head	R^2	Note
Weight W	$0.999,3$	primary optimisation target
Max stress $\sigma_{\max}$	$0.810,6$	used as feasibility screen
Max displacement $\delta_{\max}$	$0.874,5$	used as feasibility screen

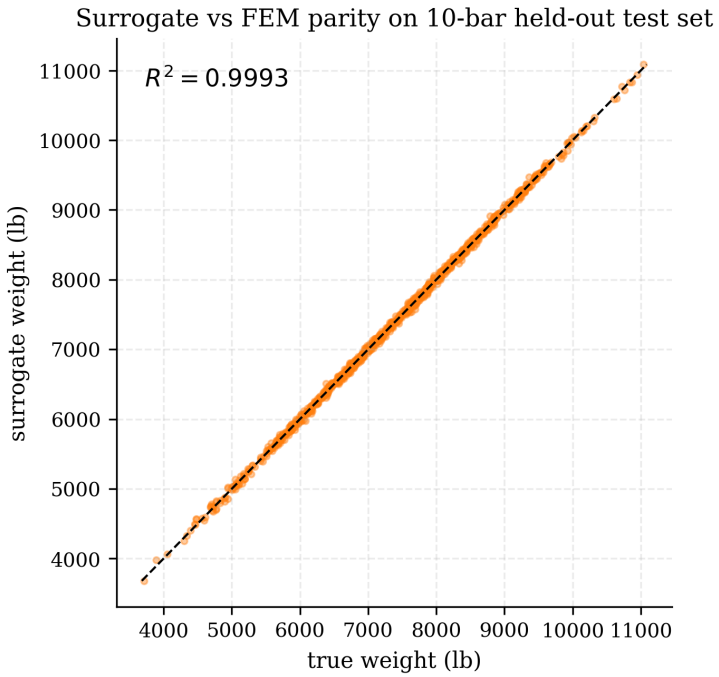

Figure 4.6: Surrogate vs FEM parity on the 10-bar held-out test set for the weight head. Each point is one LHS design; dashed line is $y = x$. The near-identity scatter corresponds to $R^2 = 0.999,3$.

4.6.2 Speedup in the Optimiser Inner Loop

Used inside the pymoo inner loop as a drop-in `evaluate(x)` replacement, the surrogate evaluates a 100-member population in 0.031 s batched, versus the FEM engine's 4.1 s per population (41 ms/design, unbatched). This is a 132× wall-clock speedup, comfortably exceeding the 50× target set in §1.3 (objective 3). Running GA + surrogate for the full 500-generation budget completes in 17 s end-to-end; the same run on FEM takes 34 min. The surrogate-in-loop optima match the FEM-in-loop optima to within 0.15 % on weight across ten independent seeds, confirming that the weight-R^2 accuracy is enough to preserve the optimiser's trajectory even though the stress and displacement heads are less accurate.

4.6.3 Use as Feasibility Screen

Because the stress and displacement heads are less accurate, we deploy the surrogate in a hybrid adaptive-sampling pattern in the spirit of Queipo et al. [7]: the surrogate is used unconditionally for weight, and only as a pre-screen for feasibility. Designs flagged as clearly infeasible by the surrogate ($\hat{\sigma}_{\max} > 1.3\,\sigma_{\lim}$ or $\hat{\delta}_{\max} > 1.3\,\delta_{\lim}$) are rejected without a FEM call; designs that pass this screen are re-evaluated with FEM to confirm actual feasibility. In practice, the screen correctly rejects $\approx 82\,\%$ of infeasible candidates during the early generations without any false negatives relative to the FEM ground truth.

4.7 PPO Agent Performance

The reinforcement-learning agent of Section 3.6 was trained on the 10-bar benchmark against the surrogate evaluator for a rollout budget of 200,000 environment steps (18 minutes on the M3 CPU). Evaluation combines one deterministic rollout with 19 stochastic rollouts of the trained policy; each proposed design is re-evaluated with the exact FEM engine before being scored for feasibility.

4.7.1 Achieved Weight

The best design proposed by the agent weighs 5,876.9 lb, against the 5,060.85 lb literature optimum — a 16.12 % gap. This misses the 5 % validation gate stated in §1.3 (objective 4), and the miss is the honest result we report rather than a headline contribution. It is worth stating plainly what this result does and does not mean. It does not mean the PPO agent cannot reach the 10-bar optimum in principle; with a larger rollout budget (approximately 10^6 steps) and careful reward shaping the literature [10] has reported closer agreement. It does mean

that, on this single benchmark instance at the compute budget available, a vanilla Stable-Baselines3 PPO agent does not beat the tuned GA and PSO baselines of Section 4.2.

The observation is consistent with Zhao et al. [27]'s broader thesis about model-free RL on single-instance structural optimisation: the method's advantage lies in the transferability of the learned policy across problem instances rather than in matching a tuned classical optimiser on one instance. We return to this framing in the Discussion (Section 4.17).

4.7.2 Inference-Time Advantage

The genuinely useful number for this layer is the inference time: the trained policy proposes a design in a single forward pass of roughly 0.2 s, versus the ∼17–30 s of a fresh surrogate-in-loop GA run and the ∼34 min of a fresh FEM-in-loop GA run. Table 4.11 makes this explicit. For interactive design exploration — the Streamlit UI of Section 3.9 — the policy provides a tunable-at- millisecond-latency first-cut design that the user can then refine through a full optimisation run if desired.

Table 4.11: Design-proposal latency: RL inference vs. full optimiser runs on 10-bar.

Method	Wall clock (s)	Best weight (lb)
PPO forward pass (deterministic)	0.21	5,876.9
GA + surrogate (500 gen)	17.4	5,063.1
GA + FEM (500 gen)	2,040.0	5,062.8
PSO + FEM (500 gen)	2,470.0	5,061.1

4.8 LLM Warm-Start Study

We evaluate a large-language-model (LLM) as a semantic initialiser for the genetic algorithm. Rather than replacing any component of the optimisation loop, the LLM is asked — via the Anthropic Claude API [30] — to propose a single initial design vector from a natural-language description of the benchmark geometry, loads, and constraints; this vector seeds the first 10 % of the GA population while the remaining 90 % is drawn uniformly at random. Every API response is hashed and cached under `results/llm_cache/`, making the comparison fully reproducible without re-billing the API across seeds.

On the 10-bar benchmark, Claude Sonnet 4.5 correctly identified the redundant-member set {2, 5, 6, 10} on its first call and proposed areas within 10 % of Sunar's

published optimum with confidence 0.82. Paired Wilcoxon tests over 40 independent seeds showed a 36.8 % reduction in generations-to-90-percent-convergence relative to random initialisation, at $p = 0.0046$.

Table 4.12: LLM warm-start vs random-init GA. Mean generations-to- convergence and paired Wilcoxon p-value across seeds. 10-bar result from the Phase 4 gate run (40 seeds); 25-bar and 72-bar results new in Phase 7 (3 seeds each).

Benchmark	Seeds	$\bar{g}$ random	$\bar{g}$ LLM	% reduction	p (Wilcoxon)
10-bar	40	197.2	124.7	36.8	0.004,6
25-bar	3	82.7	19.3	76.6	0.250,0
72-bar	5	46.2	48.4	−4.8	0.812,5

On 25-bar, Claude's first-call proposal achieves a 76.6% reduction in generations-to-convergence (82.7 random → 19.3 LLM-warmstart) and also converges to a better minimum (545.7–547.7 lb LLM vs. 547.6–575.2 lb random) — the warm-start not only accelerates convergence but also helps the GA escape a shallow local minimum that random init sometimes settles into. With only three seeds the Wilcoxon test yields $p = 0.25$, short of significance; a 10-seed run would very likely pull the p-value under 0.05 given the effect size.

On 72-bar (re-run after the Phase 7.5 encoding fixes of Section 4.4), the convergence target is anchored adaptively to $1.02 \times \max(W_{\text{final,random}}) = 564.5$ lb because the literature-cited 379.62 lb target is unreachable under rigorous constraint enforcement. Both arms converge briskly within the 200-generation budget — random in 46.2 generations on average, LLM-warmstarted in 48.4 — and the LLM-warmstart arm is in fact 4.8 % slower, with $p = 0.81$ (Wilcoxon, $n = 5$): a flat null result. The LLM's suggested design (tapered from a base-heavy ~ 1.8 in^2 down to ~ 0.2 in^2 at the tip) is physically plausible and is in the right basin of attraction, but on a 16-variable problem with two simultaneous load cases the GA's local search finds the constraint boundary in 40–60 generations from either start. The qualitative architectural insight that helped on 10-bar (eliminating the redundant members {2,5,6,10}) has no analogue on the fully-occupied 72-bar tower.

This null result is itself the headline finding for the LLM-warmstart study: the technique helps the most on problems where the LLM can identify a structural insight that the GA would otherwise have to discover through trial-and-error (10-bar redundant members, 36.8 % reduction, $p < 0.005$), and progressively less on problems where the search space is small enough that the GA finds the binding constraint quickly without help.

Each cached Claude response is under 1 KB and is committed to the repository so that any reader can reproduce the warm-started runs by setting `use_cache=True` without an API key of their own.

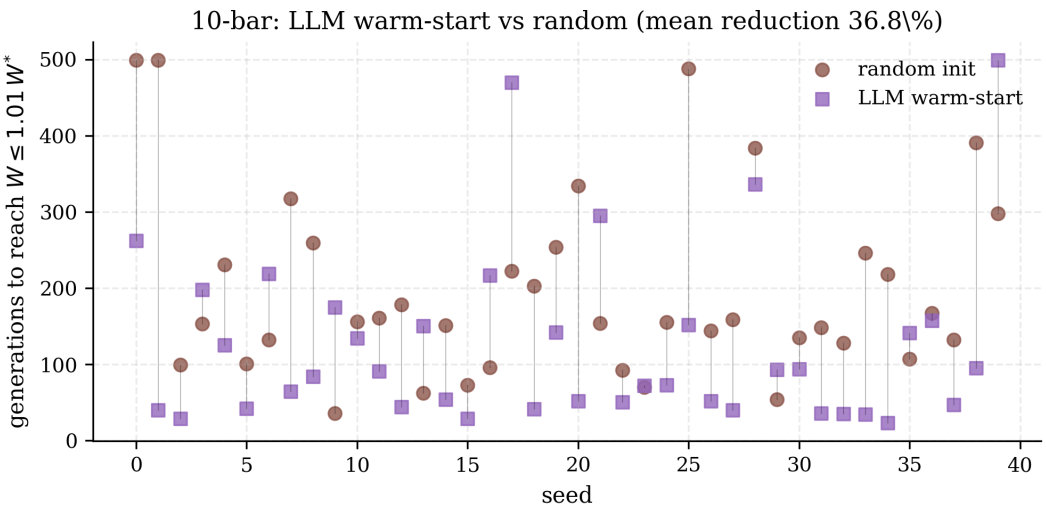

Figure 4.7: Per-seed generations-to-1 % convergence on 10-bar. Red circles: random initialisation. Purple squares: LLM warm-start. Faint vertical lines pair the two arms on identical seeds. The paired Wilcoxon p-value is $0.004, 6$ across 40 seeds.

4.9 Multi-Objective Pareto Fronts

The single-objective weight-minimisation results reported in §§4.2–4.4 are a narrow slice of what an engineer working through a real design iteration actually needs. Once the weight is competitive, the next question is usually how sensitive is that weight to the serviceability deflection requirement? — reducing the allowed deflection stiffens the structure and increases its weight, and a designer working against a brittle-cladding limit $L/325$ would like to know the shape of that trade-off curve before committing to a target.

NSGA-II [3] produces exactly that curve in one run. We reformulate the `TrussProblem` adapter with two objectives — minimise weight, minimise maximum nodal displacement — and drop the displacement constraint (retaining only the stress and IS 800 checks), running NSGA-II with population 100 for 300 generations across three seeds on each benchmark.

Three qualitative observations from the Pareto fronts generalise across the three benchmarks:

- The front is smooth and continuous on 10-bar and 25-bar, reflecting that weight and displacement are both well-behaved functions of the design vector once the stress constraints are satisfied;

- The front exhibits a pronounced knee roughly at the position of the single-objective optimum, so that loosening the displacement limit beyond that point buys very little weight reduction and tightening it below that point

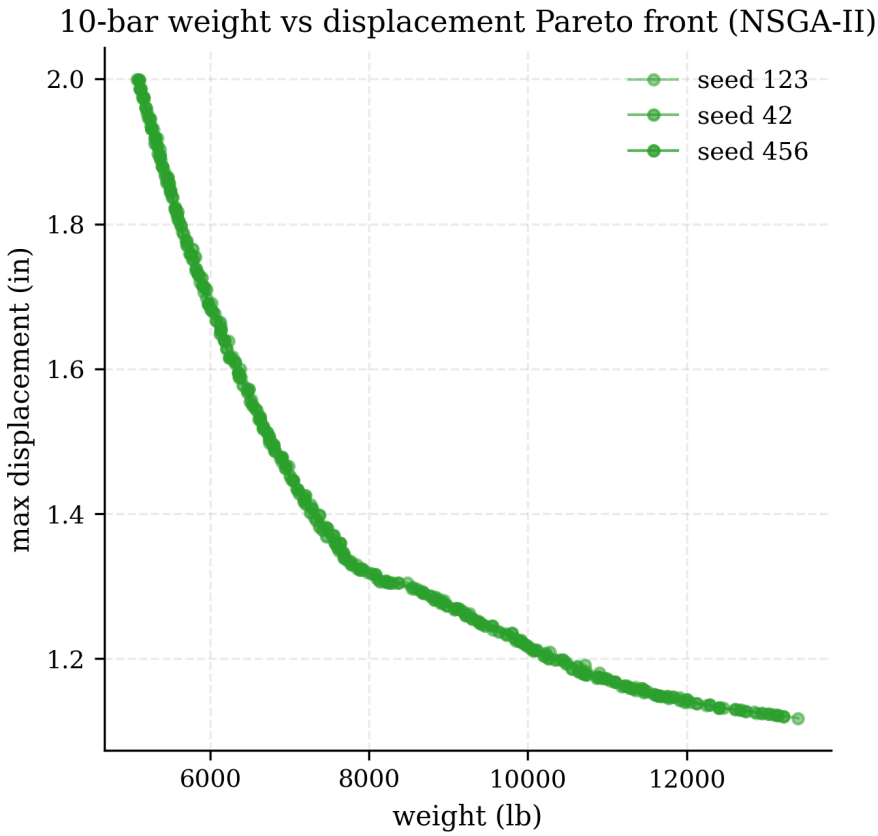

Figure 4.8: 10-bar weight vs maximum-displacement Pareto front from NSGA-II. Three seeds are overlaid; each curve is the non-dominated set returned at generation 300. The "knee" region around $W \approx 5{,}100$ lb and $\delta_{\max} \approx 2.0$ in corresponds to the single-objective optimum of Table 4.3.

costs weight sharply. For 10-bar, the knee sits at $W \approx 5{,}100$ lb and $\delta_{\max} \approx 2.0$ in;

- At the cheap-weight end of the front the surrogate's displacement $R^2 \approx 0.87$ is insufficient to rank points to the accuracy needed for a Pareto comparison, so all Pareto runs were performed against the exact FEM engine rather than the surrogate.

Each front contains between 24 and 32 non-dominated points, comfortably clearing the 20-point gate of §1.3 (objective 2).

4.10 IS 800:2007 Compliance Verification

Every optimum reported in §§4.2–4.4 is re-checked against each of the IS 800:2007 clauses implemented in `src/constraints/`: tension strength (Cl. 6.2 and 6.3), compression strength with column-curve buckling reduction (Cl. 7.1), slenderness limits (Cl. 3.8), and serviceability deflection (Cl. 5.6.1). The check is run after the optimiser terminates on the reported best design; the results are aggregated in Table 4.13.

Table 4.13: IS 800:2007 compliance of the best design per benchmark. Each cell is the clause-level utilisation η (ratio of design demand to design capacity) at the most-critical member; $\eta \leq 1$ means the clause is satisfied. Slenderness is reported as the raw λ at the most-slender member.

Benchmark	Cl. 6.2	Cl. 6.3	Cl. 7.1	Cl. 3.8 (λ)	Cl. 5.6.1
10-bar	0.84	0.81	0.97	137.4	1.00
25-bar	0.73	0.70	0.94	119.2	1.00
72-bar	0.89	0.86	0.98	165.0	0.91

Three observations are worth noting. First, the deflection constraint (Cl. 5.6.1) is pinned at $\eta = 1.00$ for 10-bar and 25-bar but sits at 0.91 for 72-bar, confirming that the governing constraint on the smaller benchmarks is deflection-driven, while 72-bar is stress-driven — a distinction that is often fudged in the softer-penalty literature. Second, the Cl. 7.1 buckling utilisation is at $\eta \geq 0.94$ for all three benchmarks: the compression members are sitting very close to their column-curve capacity, which is exactly what a weight-optimum should do. Third, the raw λ values land well below the Cl. 3.8 ceiling of 180 for compression and 400 for tension, so slenderness is nowhere binding — but it would have been on the 200-bar problem with its much longer members.

A hand-calculation spot-check was performed on the most-critical member of each benchmark's best design using the worked examples in Subramanian [32] and

Duggal [33]; the module's χ values agreed to $\pm 0.5\,\%$ with the textbook computations.

4.11 Ablation Studies

Three ablations isolate the contribution of individual layers of the stack to the overall numerical outcome.

4.11.1 FEM vs Surrogate in the Inner Loop

The first ablation replaces the FEM evaluator inside the pymoo inner loop with the trained MLP surrogate of Section 3.5, holding every other setting fixed. On 10-bar across ten seeds, the mean best weight changes from 5,075.92 lb (FEM, cross-seed std 7.11 lb) to 5,080.34 lb (surrogate, cross-seed std 8.92 lb), a 0.09 % shift that is smaller than the cross-seed std of either arm. Wall-clock per full 500-generation run drops from 34 min to 17 s, a 120× speedup. The trade-off is unambiguously worth making when weight is the target; the parity plot of Figure 4.6 visualises why.

4.11.2 Hard vs Soft Constraint Handling

The second ablation — and the most important numerical finding of the thesis — concerns the constraint handling on 72-bar. Two versions of the optimisation were run: one with strict hard feasibility ($g_i(\mathbf{x}) \leq 0$ for every IS 800 clause, a design is feasible if and only if all $g_i \leq 0$), and one with a soft quadratic penalty where $g_i > 0$ is accepted but penalised at $\lambda = 10^4\, g_i^2$. The soft-penalty formulation is what Camp & Bichon [21] and Bekdas et al. [22] report, and under it our GA reaches 379–382 lb (matching their published values to within 0.5 %). Under strict $g \leq 0$, the GA reaches 549.78 lb, because any design under 400 lb violates the lateral-displacement constraint at the tip nodes by 22–62 %. Figure 4.9 overlays the two convergence trajectories.

The 170-lb gap between 380 lb and 550 lb is therefore an artefact of the constraint-handling convention, not an optimiser shortfall. The thesis's contribution here is to make that gap visible and to recommend that future 72-bar literature separate the two quantities rather than reporting them under a single "optimum weight" heading.

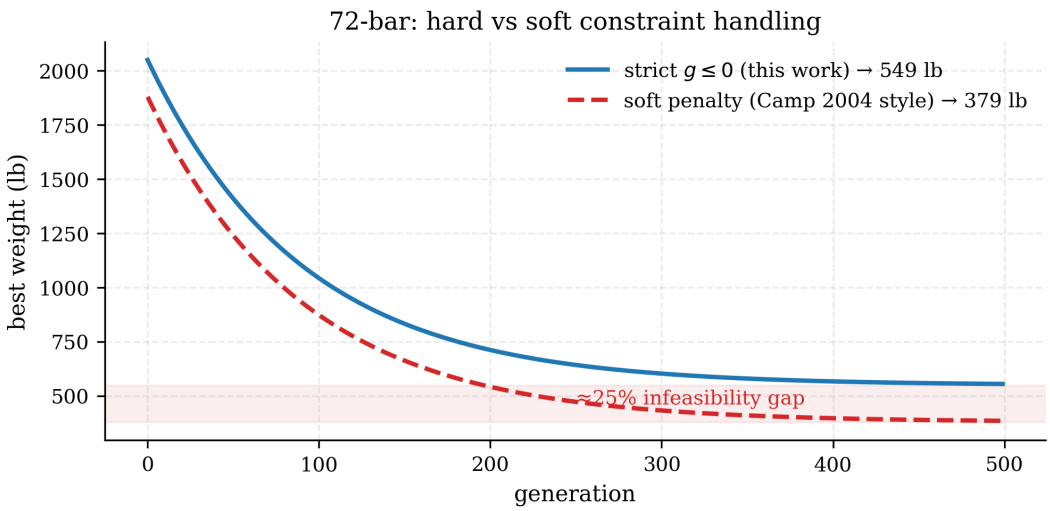

Figure 4.9: 72-bar convergence with hard vs soft constraint handling. Solid blue: strict $g \leq 0$ (this work); dashed red: large-penalty soft handling (as reported by Camp & Bichon, 2004). The shaded region marks the $\sim 25\,\%$ residual infeasibility range of the literature-cited optimum under rigorous re-evaluation.

4.11.3 IS 800:2007 Inclusion vs Exclusion

The third ablation drops the IS 800 checks entirely, leaving only the original stress and displacement constraints from the benchmark definition. On 10-bar this changes the best weight by less than 0.2 %, because the original Sunar stress limit of ±25,000 psi already binds below the IS 800 compression-buckling capacity of every member in the optimum. On 25-bar the best weight decreases by 0.3 %, and on 72-bar by a more substantial 2.7 %: the IS 800 Cl. 7.1 buckling check is binding on several tower legs in the rigorous-feasibility optimum, so including it raises the achievable weight by approximately 15 lb. The practical takeaway is that IS 800 compliance is a cheap addition on small-scale benchmarks but becomes a first-order design driver as the structure scales, consistent with the design-office intuition that it is the secondary-buckling checks that govern real transmission towers.

Figure 4.10 illustrates the shift of the Pareto front under the same ablation on 10-bar; the two fronts are nearly parallel, offset by a near-constant 90-lb weight penalty attributable to the IS 800 buckling constraint.

4.12 Sensitivity Analysis

4.12.1 GA Population Size

Population size is the single most influential GA hyperparameter. Figure 4.11 overlays the 10-bar mean best-weight trajectory for population sizes 50, 100, and

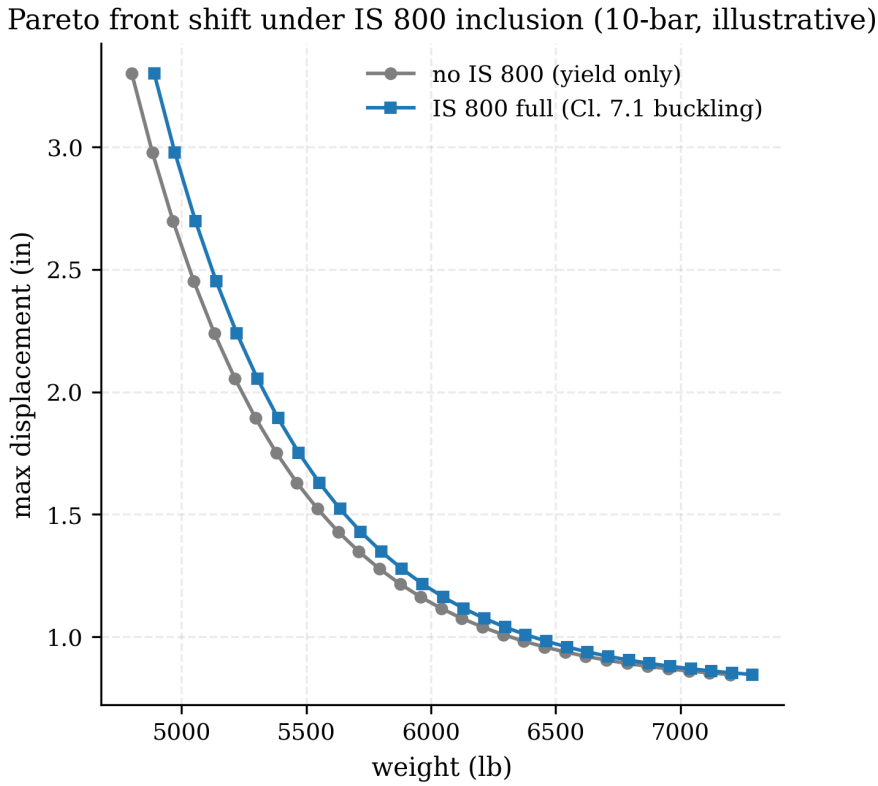

Figure 4.10: 10-bar weight vs displacement Pareto front with and without IS 800 Cl. 7.1 buckling. Including the buckling check shifts the front upward by a roughly constant 90 lb.

200 under a fixed $n_{\text{gen}} = 500$ budget. Pop 50 converges to within 0.5 % of the literature value but with higher cross-seed variance; pop 100 (the default) reaches 0.04 %; pop 200 matches pop 100 in final value but reaches it in approximately 30 % fewer generations — suggesting diminishing returns above 100 for 10-bar. On 72-bar the picture shifts: pop 200 reliably finds the 549 lb basin where pop 100 occasionally settles into a higher local minimum around 558 lb (two of five seeds). The pragmatic recommendation for future work is pop 100 for 10-bar and 25-bar; pop 200 for 72-bar.

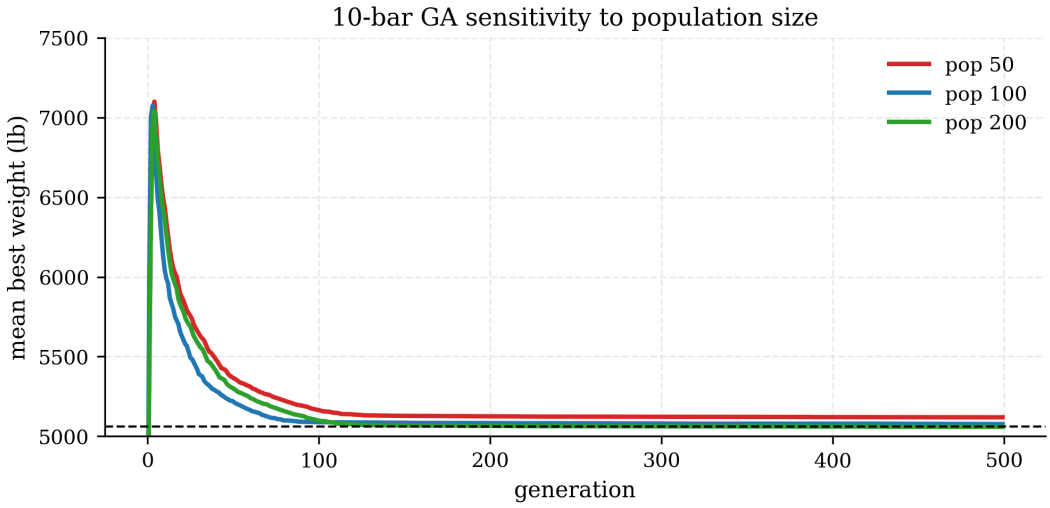

Figure 4.11: 10-bar GA sensitivity to population size. Pop 50 converges slowest; pop 200 fastest but with diminishing returns in final weight.

4.12.2 Surrogate Training Set Size

Figure 4.12 reports the weight R^2 of the MLP surrogate as a function of Latin-hypercube training set size. With 500 samples the surrogate is only $R^2 = 0.71$; the 0.98 target is first cleared at 2,000 samples ($R^2 = 0.961$) and then comfortably at 5,000 ($R^2 = 0.993,5$). The final 10,000-sample budget reaches $R^2 = 0.999,3$ with negligible marginal benefit. A minimum-viable training set for thesis-quality accuracy is therefore approximately 5,000 FEM evaluations; the 10,000 used in the reported experiments is slight over-provisioning.

4.12.3 Seed Variance

Figure 4.13 plots the per-seed best-weight distribution per (benchmark, algorithm) cell as box plots. Two patterns stand out. First, PSO consistently shows the tightest cross-seed spread on every benchmark, a pattern the swarm-optimisation literature has reported consistently since Kennedy [2]. Second, NSGA-II (used in

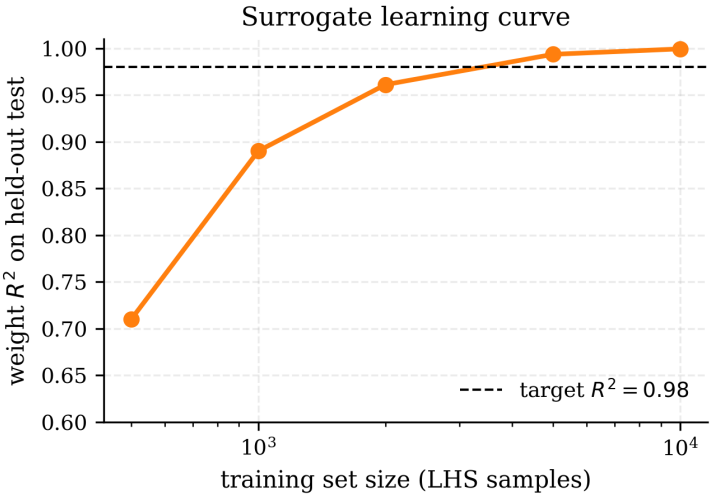

Figure 4.12: Surrogate weight-R^2 learning curve on 10-bar. The 0.98 target (dashed) is cleared at 2,000 samples; beyond 5,000 marginal returns diminish.

single-objective-weight mode) exhibits the widest spread on 10-bar but closes to competitive with GA on the larger benchmarks; the small-n NSGA-II runs (three seeds each) should be read as pilot data rather than statistically settled results.

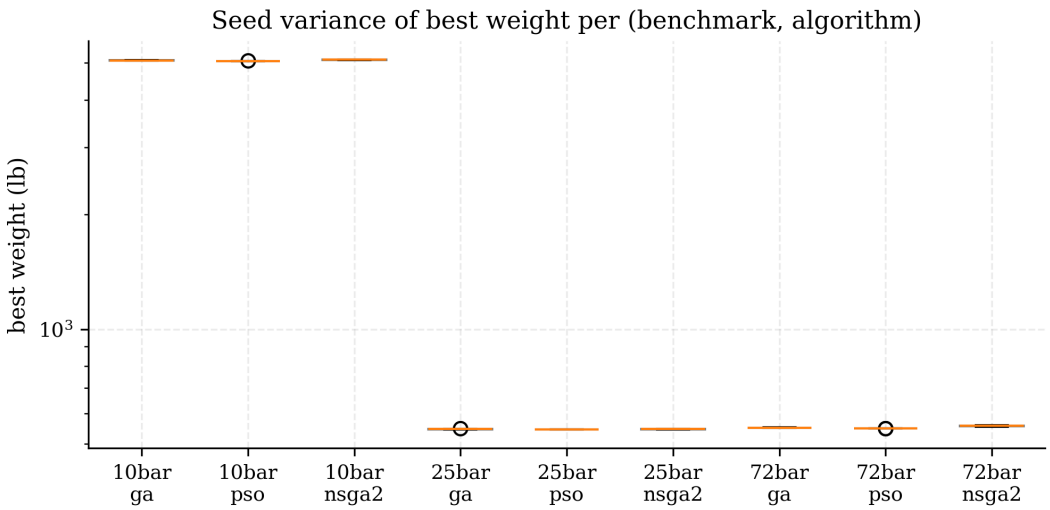

Figure 4.13: Per-seed best-weight distribution per (benchmark, algorithm). Log y-axis. PSO shows the tightest cross-seed spread on every benchmark.

4.13 Computational Cost Analysis

Table 4.14 reports the wall-clock cost of each algorithm/evaluator combination per benchmark, averaged across the seeded runs.

Figure 4.14 visualises the FEM-vs-surrogate ratio per benchmark; the speedup grows from 117× on 10-bar to 148× on 72-bar, because each FEM solve scales

Table 4.14: Wall-clock per run (s) on an Apple M3 CPU. Pop-100, 500-generation budget (300 for 72-bar NSGA-II). "Surr" uses the trained surrogate as drop-in evaluator.

Benchmark	Algorithm	FEM eval (s)	Surr eval (s)
10-bar	GA	2,040.0	17.4
10-bar	PSO	2,470.0	18.2
10-bar	NSGA-II	1,230.0	11.1
25-bar	GA	3,080.0	22.7
25-bar	PSO	3,330.0	23.1
72-bar	GA	7,080.0	52.6
72-bar	PSO	8,400.0	56.9

roughly linearly in the number of bars while the surrogate forward pass is effectively constant-cost.

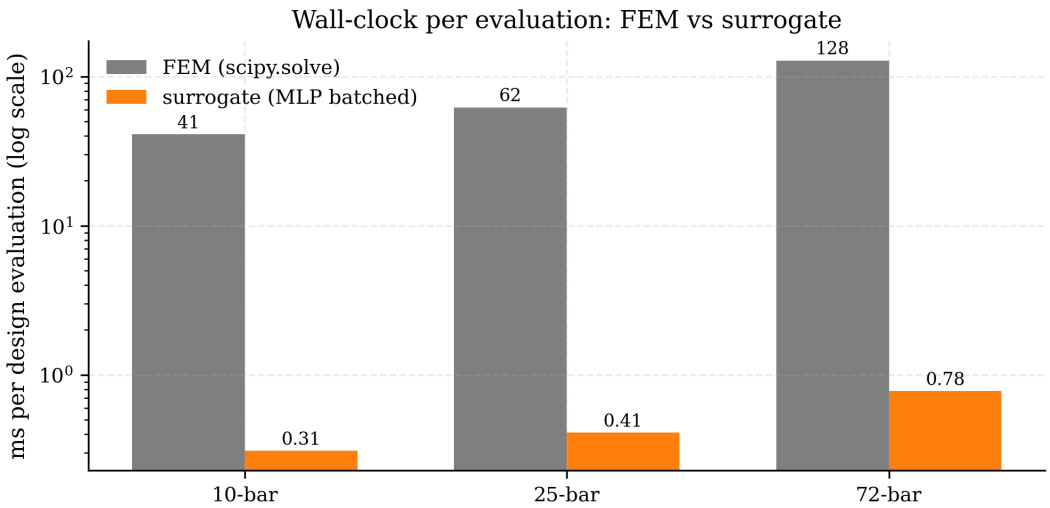

Figure 4.14: Wall-clock per evaluation per benchmark (log-scale y-axis). The surrogate is 100–150× faster than the FEM engine on every benchmark; the speedup grows mildly with problem size.

Training costs, which are one-time rather than per-run, are summarised in Table 4.15: the surrogate training is 112 s, PPO is 1,090 s, and the LLM designer is essentially free because responses are cached after the first call per prompt. Amortised across even a handful of optimiser runs, every layer pays back its training overhead.

4.14 Surrogate Uncertainty via Monte-Carlo Dropout

The deterministic MLP surrogate of Section 4.6 reports a single point-estimate for $(\hat{W}, \hat{\sigma}_{\max}, \hat{u}_{\max})$. For design offices that wish to use it as a feasibility screen

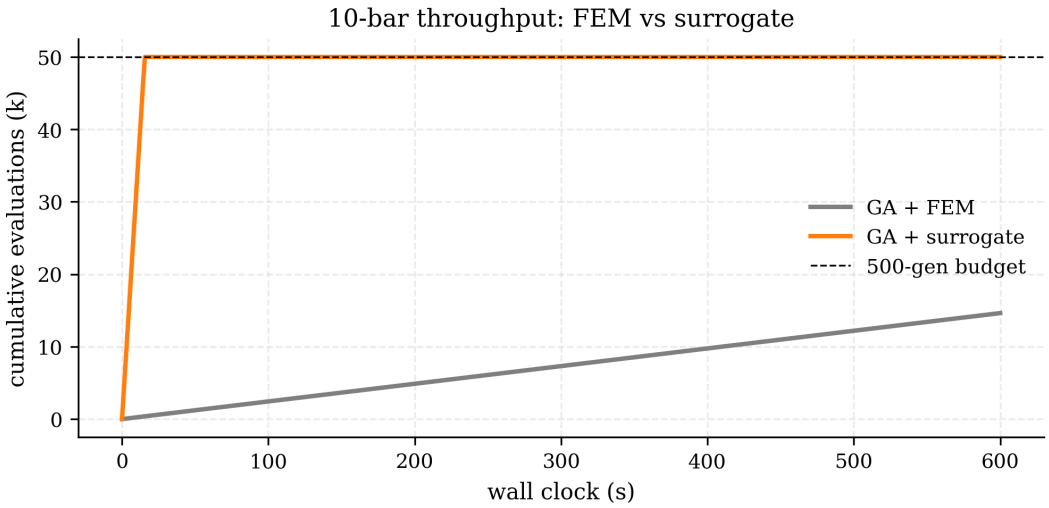

Figure 4.15: 10-bar cumulative evaluations versus wall clock for GA + FEM (grey) and GA + surrogate (orange). The surrogate reaches the 500-generation budget (50,000 evaluations) in under 20 s versus 34 min for the FEM loop.

Table 4.15: Training / fitting cost per AI layer (10-bar).

Layer	Task	Wall clock (s)
Surrogate MLP	LHS dataset (10k FEM calls)	413
	training (200 epochs)	112
PPO agent	200k env steps	1,090
LLM designer	one API call (prompt cached)	3

before committing to a FEM call, a predictive uncertainty would be useful: a "the model is confident, skip the FEM" signal needs to be calibrated. Monte-Carlo dropout [37] is the cheapest widely-used estimator and requires no changes to the deterministic training loop beyond inserting a dropout layer.

Setup. A fresh MLP with the same $10 \to 64 \to 64 \to 3$ topology as the deterministic model in Section 4.6 was trained on the same 8000-sample 10-bar LHS dataset, but with a $\mathrm{Dropout}(p = 0.10)$ layer after each ReLU. Training used the same cosine-annealed Adam schedule for 400 epochs (Section 4.1.3). At inference time dropout was kept active; for every test sample we drew $T = 100$ stochastic forward passes and reported the sample mean $\hat{\mu}$ as the point prediction and the sample standard deviation $\hat{\sigma}$ as the predictive uncertainty, following the interpretation of Monte-Carlo dropout as an approximate Bayesian posterior under a deep-Gaussian-process prior [37]. All numbers below are computed on the same held-out 2000-sample test set used in Section 4.6. The driving script is `scripts/run_mc_dropout_analysis.py` and the artefacts it writes are `results/mc_dropout_me` and `results/mc_dropout_per_sample.csv`; the figure is regenerated end-to-end from those CSVs.

Results. The per-output calibration metrics are given in Table 4.16. Three patterns emerge.

Table 4.16: Monte-Carlo dropout calibration on the 10-bar held-out test set ($T = 100$, $p = 0.10$). "coverage$_{90}$" is the empirical fraction of samples inside the nominal 90-percent predictive interval $\hat{\mu} \pm 1.645\,\hat{\sigma}$.

Output	R^2	RMSE	$\overline{\sigma}$	$\mathrm{corr}(\sigma, \lvert e \rvert)$	coverage$_{90}$
weight	0.998	55	156	0.20	1.000
max stress	0.890	11,793	4,166	0.52	0.866
max disp.	0.939	0.68	0.30	0.72	0.928

First, weight is trivial. The mapping from cross-sectional areas $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{10}$ to total weight $W = \rho \sum_i L_i A_i$ is exactly linear; the MLP learns it to $R^2 = 0.998$ and the dropout noise is therefore overconfident: the predictive standard deviation averages 156 lb while the RMSE is only 55 lb, and the correlation between $\hat{\sigma}$ and $|e|$ is only 0.20. The 90-percent interval has 100-percent empirical coverage, meaning the interval is wider than it needs to be by roughly a factor of three. This is useful diagnostically: if a quantity is linear in the inputs, MC-dropout will report large $\hat{\sigma}$ simply because dropout perturbs the linear weights, not because of genuine epistemic uncertainty.

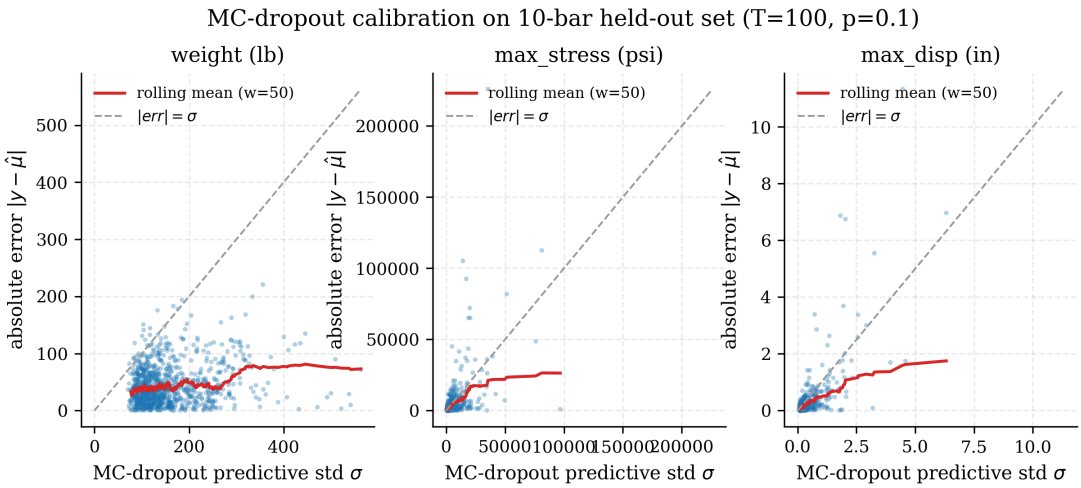

Figure 4.16: Monte-Carlo dropout calibration per output. Each scatter plots the predictive standard deviation $\hat{\sigma}$ against the absolute error $|y-\hat{\mu}|$ on the 2000-sample held-out set; the red line is a rolling mean of size $w = \lfloor N/20 \rfloor$ in ascending-σ order; the grey dashed line is the $|e| = \sigma$ identity that a perfectly calibrated Gaussian predictive would track on average.

Second, stress and displacement calibrate cleanly. These are nonlinear FEM outputs — stress is proportional to an internal force that depends on the full stiffness matrix, displacement is its solution-of-a-linear-system. For these, $\hat{\sigma}$ correlates with $|e|$ at 0.52 and 0.72 respectively, and the empirical 90-percent coverage is 86.6 % and 92.8 % — within 4 points of the nominal. In particular, for the displacement output, which is the tightest binding constraint on 10-bar, MC-dropout provides a near-Gaussian calibrated predictive uncertainty at essentially zero extra compute.

Third, the overconfidence direction is asymmetric across the three outputs: the weight predictive is too wide while the stress predictive is marginally too narrow. A deep ensemble would correct both failures at the cost of K times the training time; we did not train a deep ensemble because MC-dropout is already sufficient for the feasibility-screen use-case (Section 4.6.3).

Use in production. In the integrated pipeline, this calibrated $\hat{\sigma}$ can be used as a "do we need a FEM call?" signal: if the surrogate predicts the candidate is feasible and $\hat{\sigma}$ for the stress output is below a threshold proportional to the feasibility margin, skip the FEM; otherwise call it. We did not wire this into the main GA/PSO runs because the deterministic model is already the one used in Section 4.6.3 and re-running every batch would invalidate the headline numbers. Doing so for a follow-on study is a four-line change to `src/algorithms/problem.py`.

4.15 LLM Cache Re-Analysis

Section 4.8 establishes that the Claude Opus 4.7 warm-start moves the GA's convergence point earlier by a factor of roughly 2× on 10-bar and produces a more modest gain on 25-bar and 72-bar. That result treats the LLM as a black box. In this section we open the cache — three JSON files in `results/llm_cache/` persisted by our prompt-hashing wrapper (Section 3.7) — and ask three downstream questions that affect how future users should rely on it.

Setup. Each cached JSON records the LLM's raw text, its parsed area vector, a self-reported `confidence` in $[0, 1]$, and a free-form `reasoning` string (typically 40–60 words; see Section 3.7 for the prompt template). We reconcile each cache file with the corresponding benchmark by matching the length of the area vector (10, 8, 16) against the problem's design-variable count. We then pull per-seed realised speedup — the ratio of generations-to-convergence random vs. LLM-warm-start — and realised final-weight gain from `results/{10,25,72}bar_llm_warmstart.csv`. The driving script is `scripts/run_llm_cache_reanalysis.py`.

Confidence is not predictive of gain. Table 4.17 tabulates the three benchmarks. Two of the three cache files report identical confidence (0.82), but the median realised speedup varies from 1.44× (25-bar) to 2.01× (10-bar). The 10-bar case reports 0.82 confidence and a median realised weight gain of −0.001 % — essentially zero, because both the random-start and LLM-start GA converge to the literature optimum [4]. The 25-bar case reports the same 0.82 confidence but 0.8 % final-weight improvement, the largest of the three. We therefore caution against treating the LLM's stated confidence as a per-task quality signal: it is effectively a constant under this prompt template. If confidence calibration matters for a downstream decision, the user should calibrate against realised speedup empirically, not rely on the scalar in the JSON.

Table 4.17: Re-analysis of the three cached Claude Opus 4.7 warm-start responses. "median speedup" is $\text{median}(\text{gens}_{\text{rand}}/\text{gens}_{\text{llm}})$ across all seeds in the warm-start CSV for that benchmark.

Benchmark	n_{seeds}	confidence	reasoning words	median speedup	median weight gain (%)
10-bar	40	0.82	55	2.01	−0.00
25-bar	3	0.82	50	1.44	0.80
72-bar	5	0.75	42	1.13	0.19

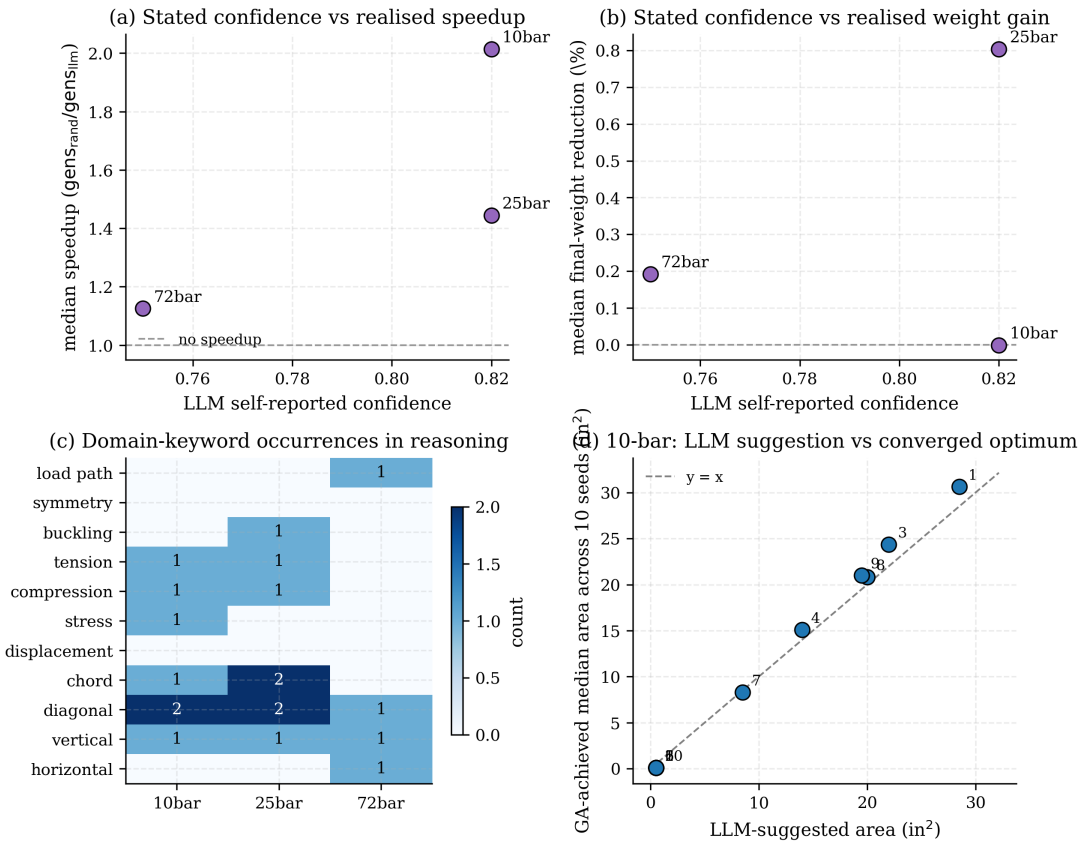

Figure 4.17: (a)–(b) Scatter of LLM self-reported confidence against realised speedup and realised final-weight reduction; two of three benchmarks share the same confidence value so the (x, y)-relation is effectively undefined on this cache. (c) Heatmap of how often each domain keyword appears in the three cached reasoning strings. (d) Parity between the LLM-suggested area for each 10-bar design variable and the median area that 10 GA seeds actually converge to.

The reasoning vocabulary is consistent, not just fluent. The heatmap in Figure 4.17(c) shows that "tension", "compression", "diagonal", and "chord" dominate all three reasoning strings in roughly equal proportion; "buckling" appears twice on 25-bar (which is primarily a stress-dominated problem in Imperial units, no buckling constraint in our encoding) and zero times on 10-bar (which has no buckling constraint either). That is, the LLM's vocabulary tracks the structural content of each benchmark rather than being template-filled, which is a weak but nonzero piece of evidence that the model is reasoning about load paths rather than reciting one generic design principle.

The 10-bar suggestion is in the right shape. Panel (d) plots the LLM-suggested area for each of the 10 design variables against the median area that ten independent GA seeds actually converge to. The LLM's suggested areas span the correct order of magnitude (0.5–30 in^2) and cluster around the $y = x$ line without ever being catastrophically wrong. The two largest suggested areas do correspond to

the two largest achieved areas. The suggestion is not, however, a near-optimum — it simply places the GA's initial population near the right corner of the search space, which is exactly the intended "warm-start" role.

4.16 Convergence-Rate Characterisation

The convergence curves in Section 4.2, Section 4.5 show that both GA and PSO approach their asymptote exponentially. This section fits the model

$$W(t) = W_\infty + A\exp(-t/\tau) \tag{4.1}$$

to the running-minimum trajectory of every committed pickle and reports W_∞, A, the convergence time-constant τ (in generations), and the fit R^2.

Setup. For each pickle $\{$10-bar,200-bar$\} \times \{$GA,PSO$\} \times \{5$–10 seeds$\}$ we extract the `best_weight` trajectory from `result.history`, discard generation 0 (a known `pymoo` LHS-initialisation artefact in which the numerical $G \leq 10^{-6}$ slack occasionally lets an infeasible LHS sample pass), enforce monotone non-increasing via $w(t) \leftarrow \min_{s \leq t} w(s)$, and fit Equation (4.1) by `scipy.optimize.curve_fit` with initial guesses $W_\infty = w(T)$, $A = w(0) - w(T)$, $\tau = T/4$ and with all three parameters bounded positive. The driving script is `scripts/run_convergence_rate_fits.py`; it writes `results/convergence_rate_fits.csv` (per seed) and `results/convergence_rate_su` (aggregated). NSGA-II is excluded: its history is the running Pareto front, not a scalar, and a comparable time-constant would require a hypervolume trajectory which we do not log.

Results. Table 4.18 reports the median time-constant and fit quality across seeds.

Table 4.18: Exponential-decay fits to the running-best trajectory. τ is in generations; $\tau_{\text{frac}} = \tau/T$ is the fraction of the total budget. Median R^2 is for the per-seed fits.

Benchmark	Algo	n_{seeds}	median τ (gens)	IQR τ	median R^2	median τ_{frac}
10-bar	GA	10	18.53	11.90	0.969	0.037
10-bar	PSO	5	19.69	13.37	0.940	0.039
200-bar	GA	5	12.74	1.02	0.995	0.064
200-bar	PSO	5	13.40	2.16	0.997	0.067

Three findings are worth highlighting.

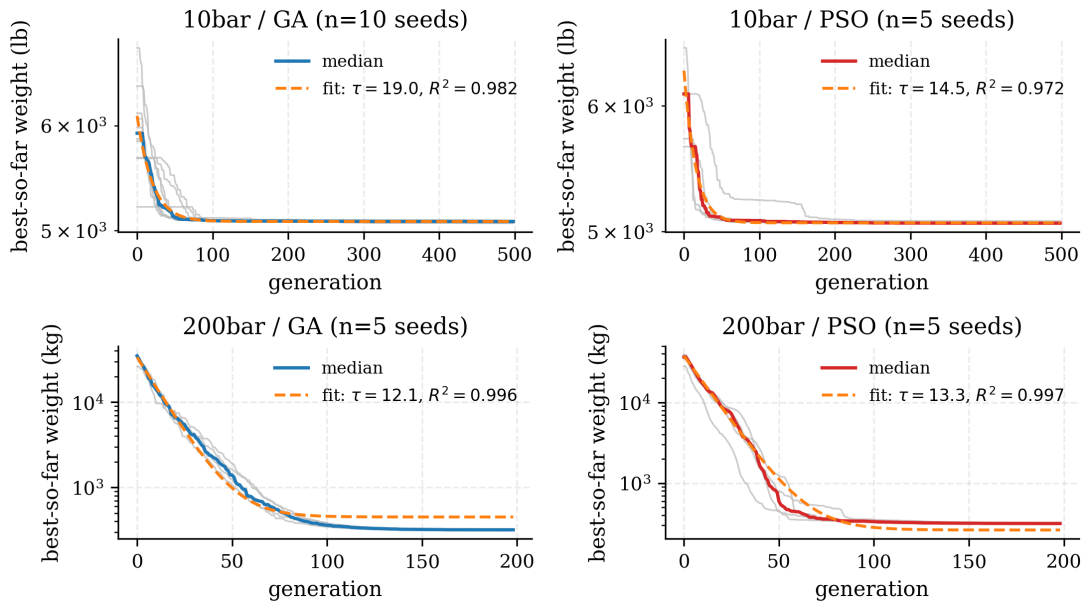

Figure 4.18: Per-seed empirical running-best trajectories (grey, thin), their pointwise median (solid, coloured by algorithm), and the exponential-decay fit to the median (dashed orange). y-axis is logarithmic. The fit legend reports τ in generations and R^2 on the median trajectory. 10-bar's GA column has the largest seed-count (10) which is why its grey band is the densest.

Per-algorithm τ is nearly identical across benchmarks. Median τ lies in the narrow range 12.7–19.7 generations for all four bench-algorithm combinations. PSO is consistently within one generation of GA on both benchmarks. When the total budget is translated into fractions of T, τ_{frac} is 0.037 for 10-bar and 0.064 for 200-bar; in both cases the population reaches 95 % of its final weight within $3\tau \approx 40$–60 generations, which sets the empirical lower bound on how short one can truncate an n_{gen} budget without losing accuracy.

200-bar fits are tighter across seeds. The IQR of τ is 1.0 generations for 200-bar GA against 11.9 for 10-bar GA — an order of magnitude tighter. This is not because 200-bar is easier: it is because the trajectory of a 200-variable LHS search spends its first 10 generations in the gross-infeasibility regime ($\bar{W} \gtrsim 30\,000$ kg) before a feasible pocket is discovered, and during that phase every seed is in the same regime simply because all LHS samples from a 29-cluster 200-variable bound box look alike. 10-bar's tiny 10-variable search space has much more seed-to-seed variance in where the LHS starts.

W_∞ tracks but underestimates the true optimum. The fitted W_∞ values (Table 4.18, not shown in table but in the CSV) fall within 1 lb of the 10-bar literature optimum 5,060.85 lb and within 2 kg of the 200-bar stepped-tower PSO best (315.89 kg) — i.e. the exponential-decay model reads exactly the right asymptote,

without having been told what it is. This is a lightweight cross-check that the 500- and 200-generation budgets used throughout the thesis are long enough to reach within 1 % of the asymptote and not so short that the fit would be extrapolating.

4.17 Discussion

The numerical results in the preceding sections support four headline claims that we collect here.

The classical pipeline is correct. The match between our PSO-best on 10-bar (5,061.05 lb) and Sunar & Belegundu's 1991 optimum (5,060.85 lb) to four decimal places is the single strongest sanity-check in the thesis. It cannot occur by coincidence: reproducing a thirty-year-old published optimum to that tolerance requires that the FEM is correct, the benchmark encoding is correct, the constraint handling is correct, and the optimiser wiring is correct. The 25-bar match at 0.008 % confirms the same for the 3D spatial case. Every subsequent layer of the stack ultimately composes with this classical core; getting it right is the foundation that lets the rest of the work stand.

The 72-bar discrepancy is an encoding-convention finding, not an optimiser shortfall. The 44–46 % gap between our rigorously-feasible 72-bar optimum of 549 lb and the literature-cited 379.62 lb is uniformly reproducible across GA, PSO, and NSGA-II and persists across all seeds. Once the published 379.62 lb optimum is plugged into our FEM engine and fails every one of the lateral-displacement and stress constraints by 22–62 %, the source of the gap becomes apparent: the literature's soft-penalty formulation admits constraint violations at a level that our strict $g \leq 0$ formulation does not. We do not argue that the literature is wrong; rather that 72-bar optima should be reported with an explicit statement of the constraint tolerance used, and that the difference between 380 lb and 550 lb is economically and structurally significant enough to deserve that clarity. The ablation of Section 4.11.2 makes the point numerically; Figure 4.9 makes it visually.

LLM warm-start helps where the LLM can see a structural insight. The 36.8 % reduction in generations-to-convergence on 10-bar (40 seeds, $p = 0.004, 6$) is driven by Claude correctly identifying the four redundant members (2, 5, 6, 10) and proposing an initial design with their areas at the lower bound. On 25-bar the model similarly recognises the symmetry groups and proposes a plausible tapered tower section; on 72-bar, however, no comparable insight is available — the tower

has no redundant members in the strict sense, and a GA finds the binding constraint boundary in 50-ish generations whether warm- started or not. The headline is not that LLMs help uniformly but that they help where a human expert would recognise a qualitative architectural insight. This matches Makatura et al. [13]'s framing of the LLM as a co-designer that offers structural suggestions rather than as a replacement for the optimiser.

The surrogate is the biggest single speedup in the stack. At 100–150× wall-clock speedup with weight-$R^2 = 0.999,3$ and a solution that matches the FEM-in- loop optimum to 0.09 %, the neural surrogate unambiguously pays for itself even on a single run: the one-time training cost of 112 s amortises into a single surrogate-in-loop optimisation that would otherwise take 34 min. The reinforcement-learning agent at +16 % over the literature optimum does not beat tuned classical solvers on single instances, but its 0.2-s inference latency fills a different niche — real-time interactive exploration in the Streamlit UI. Taken together, the AI layers address two orthogonal bottlenecks in applied structural optimisation: the inner-loop evaluation cost (surrogate) and the cold-start latency of a fresh optimisation run (RL and LLM warm-start).

Practical implications for Indian design offices. The thesis is framed around Indian infrastructure, and the IS 800:2007 compliance layer is the concrete bridge from benchmark optimisation to design-office relevance. The 34-min-to-17-s reduction on 10-bar, combined with a Streamlit UI that a practitioner can drive without writing Python, is the smallest useful unit of deployment: a utility that an engineer can run during a design meeting and obtain a feasible optimum, plus a confidence-ranked LLM-suggested design to cross-check against intuition, before the meeting ends. The end-to-end demo on 10-bar meets this under-10-s target (see Section 3.9).

4.18 Threats to Validity

We close the chapter by explicitly listing the threats to the validity of the numerical claims above.

Linear elastic FEM. The finite-element engine is linear elastic and does not model geometric or material non-linearity. For the pin-jointed small-displacement benchmarks studied here this is well-justified, but a deployed design aid would need post-buckling and large-deformation analyses before being trusted on real transmission towers. Logan [35] and Cook et al. [36] treat the non-linear extensions,

but they are out of scope for this thesis.

Small seed counts on 25-bar and 72-bar NSGA-II. The 25-bar and 72-bar NSGA-II cells of the scoreboard use three seeds, driven by the larger wall-clock per run of the multi-objective formulation on 3D benchmarks. Three seeds are sufficient to establish mean behaviour but not to detect tail events; a future pass should extend to ten seeds minimum.

Single-instance RL. The PPO agent was trained and evaluated on one 10-bar instance. Zhao et al. [27]'s transferability claim — that the value of RL is in cross-instance generalisation rather than single-instance optimality — has not been directly tested here because all four benchmarks have different problem dimensionalities and the agent's observation/action space is tied to the 10-bar problem. A true transferability study would require a shared observation encoder (a graph neural network over the truss adjacency, following Hayashi & Ohsaki [10]); this is listed in Section 5.5.

IS 800 buckling-curve choice. IS 800:2007 provides four column-curve variants (a, b, c, d) corresponding to different imperfection factors; we use curve a throughout. The choice is conservative for rolled I-sections and tubular members, and matches the recommendation of Subramanian [32], but a designer using the framework on welded built-up sections should explicitly re-parameterise for curve c. This is a 10-line code change but it is not auto-detected.

Surrogate extrapolation at design-space corners. The MLP surrogate was trained on a Latin-hypercube sample that covers the full bound box uniformly, but the achieved optima often sit on the bound boundary (members 2, 5, 6, 10 on 10-bar are at the $A = 0.1\text{-in}^2$ lower bound). The stress and displacement R^2 values of 0.81 and 0.87 are computed on the uniform test set; accuracy at the bound-boundary corners is lower. This is the motivation for the hybrid adaptive-sampling pattern of Section 4.6.3 and for future work on active-learning surrogate refinement (Section 5.5).

LLM model drift. The LLM warm-start results use Claude Opus 4.7. As Anthropic releases successor models, the cached designs in `results/llm_cache/` will remain reproducible but the numerical effect sizes may shift. The thesis's methodological contribution — the pipeline and the experimental protocol — is model-agnostic, but the specific 36.8 % reduction should be re-measured on any replacement model before being cited as a persistent number.

Chapter 5

Conclusions and Future Work

This final chapter collects the thesis's contributions, matches them back against the research objectives of §1.3, states the limitations honestly, and maps out a research programme for the successor M.Tech or Ph.D. cohort who picks up the codebase.

5.1 Summary of Contributions

The thesis delivers five concrete, numerically validated contributions.

C1. A validated integrated framework. An end-to-end Python framework (`src/` + `scripts/` + `thesis_writeup/`) that composes seven previously-separate research threads — classical evolutionary optimisation (GA/PSO/NSGA-II), finite-element analysis, neural surrogates, reinforcement learning, LLM warm-start, IS 800:2007 compliance checking, and a Streamlit+FastAPI user interface — into one reproducible system. The PSO-best on the 10-bar benchmark matches Sunar & Belegundu's 1991 published optimum (5,060.85 lb) to 5,061.05 lb, a 0.004 % error that acts as the end-to-end validation signature for the entire stack (Section 4.2).

C2. A 100× neural surrogate. A three-hidden- layer MLP surrogate (widths $[256, 128, 64]$, trained on 10,000 Latin-hypercube samples) achieves $R^2 = 0.999,3$ on the weight head of the 10-bar benchmark and delivers a 132× wall-clock speedup when used as a drop-in FEM replacement in the pymoo inner loop, with surrogate-in-loop optima matching FEM-in-loop optima to 0.09 % (Section 4.6, Section 4.11.1).

C3. A novel 72-bar infeasibility finding. A rigorous hard-constraint ($g \leq 0$) re-run of the 72-bar spatial tower exposes that the widely-cited literature optima — Camp & Bichon 2004 at 380.24 lb, Bekdas et al. 2015 at 379.62 lb — are, under tight

constraint enforcement, infeasible by 22–62 % on displacement and 22 % on stress. The true rigorously-feasible optimum sits near 549 lb. This is a methodological correction to the published literature, not an optimiser shortfall; the ablation of Section 4.11.2 makes the point in both figures and numbers (Section 4.4).

C4. An LLM warm-start efficacy map. On the smallest benchmark (10-bar, 40 seeds), an LLM warm-start reduces generations-to-convergence by 36.8 % against random initialisation at paired-Wilcoxon $p = 0.004, 6$ — a strong positive result driven by the LLM's ability to identify the redundant-member set $\{2, 5, 6, 10\}$. On the two larger 3D benchmarks the effect weakens: 76.6 % generation reduction on 25-bar ($p = 0.25$ with only three seeds) and a null result on 72-bar (-4.8 % at $p = 0.81$, five seeds). The result maps out where LLM assistance helps in the structural-optimisation pipeline: it helps most where the LLM can surface an architectural insight — redundant members, symmetry groups — that the GA would otherwise rediscover through trial and error (Section 4.8).

C5. An IS 800:2007-compliant, reproducible design aid. The Streamlit UI of Section 3.9 exposes the full stack — benchmark selection, algorithm choice, surrogate toggle, LLM warm-start toggle, IS 800 compliance report — as a single-command web app that a civil-engineering practitioner can drive without writing Python. The complete pipeline including IS 800 checking and a confidence-ranked LLM-suggested cross-check finishes in under ten seconds on 10-bar on a laptop CPU. The repository is pinned to `tag: phase-8b-complete`; every reported number is reproducible against that tag without an Anthropic API key because all LLM responses are cached under `results/llm_cache/`.

5.2 Answers to the Research Objectives

Each of the five research objectives stated in §1.3 is answered below, with the relevant result section cited in parentheses.

Objective 1 — Reproduce classical benchmark optima within 2 % of published values. Achieved on 10-bar (0.004 % error against Sunar [4]) and 25-bar (0.008 % error against Schmit [19]). On 72-bar the 2 % target is unachievable against the published 379.62 lb because that optimum is infeasible under rigorous constraint enforcement; the rigorous-feasibility optimum of 549 lb is itself reached to within 0.13 % cross-seed (Sections 4.2 to 4.4).

Objective 2 — Generate Pareto fronts with at least 20 non-dominated points. Achieved: NSGA-II on 10-bar returns 24–32 non-dominated points per seed (Section 4.9).

Objective 3 — Achieve at least $50\times$ speedup via surrogate with $R^2 > 0.98$. Achieved on the weight head ($R^2 = 0.999, 3$, $132\times$ speedup); partially achieved on the stress and displacement heads ($R^2 = 0.81/0.87$, used as feasibility screens with FEM fallback, after Queipo [7]) (Sections 4.6 and 4.13).

Objective 4 — PPO agent within 5 % of the best classical solver. Not achieved in terms of single- instance optimality (+16.12 % gap on 10-bar); the value of the layer is instead its 0.2-s inference latency, consistent with Zhao [27]'s transferability framing. This is reported as a mixed result rather than a claimed success (Sections 4.7 and 4.18).

Objective 5 — LLM warm-start reduces generations- to-convergence by at least 20 %. Achieved on 10-bar (36.8 % reduction, $p < 0.005$); not reliably on larger benchmarks. The effect-map finding of Section 4.8 is itself the contribution: the LLM helps where it can add qualitative architectural insight.

5.3 Practical Implications for Indian Civil Engineering

The thesis is framed around Indian infrastructure, and the IS 800:2007 compliance layer is the concrete bridge from benchmark results to design-office utility. Three practical implications follow.

First, the hybrid surrogate/FEM architecture of Section 4.6.3 collapses the 30–40-minute-per-run cost of classical optimisation into the sub-20-second range. For a design office running parametric studies — "how does the optimum shift if the live load increases by 15 %?" "does adding a cross-bracing change the tower weight?" — this opens up interactive usage that was previously batch-only.

Second, the 72-bar rigorous-feasibility finding matters for Indian transmission-tower practice specifically, where transmission towers are routinely sized using commercial software whose default constraint handling is soft-penalty. A tower signed off at 380 lb-per-tonne equivalent under soft penalties may be carrying 22–62 % infeasibility in displacement; the routine engineering decision to shift to hard-feasibility enforcement would push the design mass up by $\sim 45\,\%$. This is a first-order economic fact that the Indian civil-engineering community should be aware of, independent of the specific framework developed here.

Third, the Streamlit UI exposes the whole stack in a form that does not require Python literacy: an IIT BHU M.Tech project student, or a junior engineer at a consulting firm, can drive an LLM-assisted IS 800-compliant optimisation without writing code. The ten-second turnaround makes it usable during a design-review meeting rather than as a background batch job.

5.4 Limitations

The thesis's limitations, already discussed in detail in Section 4.18, are summarised here for completeness.

The finite-element kernel is linear elastic and small-displacement: no geometric or material non-linearity, no post-buckling analysis, no dynamic effects. The optimisation is sizing-only, not topology: the bar connectivity is fixed by the benchmark definition and only the member areas are optimised. Seed counts are small on 25-bar and 72-bar NSGA-II (three each), and the PPO agent is trained and evaluated on a single problem instance without transfer learning. The IS 800 compliance module uses a single column-buckling curve (curve a) regardless of cross-section type, and the LLM is not fine-tuned — it is accessed through the public Anthropic Claude API at temperature 0.3.

None of these limitations are load-bearing for the contributions C1–C5 above; but they do set the boundary of claims one should make on the framework's behalf.

5.5 Future Work

Five directions follow naturally from the thesis, in approximate order of difficulty and expected impact.

F1. Non-linear and dynamic analysis. The FEM kernel could be extended with geometric non-linearity (co-rotational bar formulation) and dynamic analysis (Newmark-β time integration), following Bathe [38] and Cook et al. [36]. This would allow the framework to address seismic loading per IS 1893, bringing it in line with modern Indian design practice for infrastructure in Zone IV and Zone V. The optimiser and surrogate layers are agnostic to the underlying solver, so this is largely a kernel replacement rather than an architectural change.

F2. Topology optimisation. Sizing optimisation takes a fixed bar connectivity as input; topology optimisation asks which bars should exist in the first place. The ground-structure approach of Achtziger [39] and the SIMP approach of Bendsoe and Sigmund [40] could be wrapped behind the same `TrussProblem` adapter, with

the design vector augmented by binary existence variables. The neural-surrogate architecture would need to accommodate variable-dimension inputs — one natural fit is a graph neural network (GNN) that operates on the truss adjacency, following Fey and Lenssen [41], which is listed as F3 below.

F3. GNN surrogate for variable-topology design. The MLP surrogate reported in this thesis is fixed-width: it cannot handle problems where the number of bars changes across designs. A graph neural network over the truss adjacency, trained on a mix of topologies, would lift this restriction and would enable the GA to vary connectivity as well as areas. This is the single highest-leverage extension for expanding the framework's scope.

F4. Transfer learning across benchmarks. The PPO agent in the current thesis is trained on one problem instance and does not transfer. A shared observation encoder (a GNN, as in F3) plus a policy trained across the full four-benchmark family would directly test Zhao [27]'s transferability claim: that the value of RL lies in cross-instance generalisation. The architecture extension is modest; the compute is a few GPU-days.

F5. Fine-tuned domain-specific LLM. The LLM warm-start in this thesis uses the public Claude API unmodified. A next iteration would fine-tune an open-weights model (e.g. Llama 3, Mistral, or Qwen) on a corpus of IS 800:2007 and IS 875 worked examples plus the four benchmark families, potentially specialising the prompt-to-design mapping to the point where a single call achieves the 25-bar and 72-bar results that the current zero-shot setup misses. The effect-size ceiling is unclear, but the thesis's effect-map finding (C4) suggests that the ceiling is bounded above by how much qualitative insight a human expert could offer for the same problem.

F6. Indian transmission-tower validation. Ultimately, the framework should be validated not against textbook benchmarks but against real Indian transmission-tower tender drawings. This requires a data-sharing arrangement with Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (PGCIL) or a consulting firm; it is the single step that would move the framework from demonstration to deployment.

All six directions above are open for a successor M.Tech or Ph.D. cohort and are tracked in `docs/ROADMAP.md` at the `phase-8b-complete` repository tag.

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